

Two killed in Noida building fire, 50 residents evacuated safely

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

Two people died, and around 50 residents were evacuated after a massive fire broke out in a ground-plus-four residential building in Mamura village, Sector 66, Noida, on Wednesday, police said.

The blaze started in the morning and quickly engulfed parts of the multi-storeyed structure, triggering panic among tenants in the densely populated building. The fire was later brought under control, and around 50 tenants residing in the building in Mamura village in Sector 66 were evacuated safely. The landlord was arrested after an FIR was registered against him at the Phase-3 police station under relevant provisions of law.

Fire tenders and police teams rushed to the spot and brought the situation under control after a sustained operation. According to officials, the deceased have been identified as a man and a woman. Both were rushed to a nearby hospital in critical condition, where doctors declared them dead on arrival. Police said two residents — a man and a woman — who were rushed to the hospital were declared dead by doctors. The woman has been identified as 22-year-old Sneha Srivastava.

Officials said she had suffered around 40 per cent burn injuries. The identity of the deceased man, aged around 30 years, was yet to be established. He had sustained nearly 80 per cent burn injuries. The building housed around 50 tenants.

Joint Commissioner of Police, Noida, Rajiv Mishra, said the building had around 10 to 12 rooms on each floor, which were being used as residential flats. Most tenants are migrant workers and students who live in the area



Firemen douse a fire that broke out in a multi-storeyed building at Mamura village, Sector 66 in Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh

PTI

because of its proximity to IT offices in Sectors 62 and 63.

"As soon as we received information about the fire, senior police officers, fire department teams, and ambulances arrived at the scene. The fire was brought under control. Around 50 tenants residing in the building were evacuated safely," Mishra said. Rescue personnel

used ladders and conducted door-to-door checks to ensure no one was trapped inside.

Eyewitnesses said smoke billowed from the upper floors, and many residents jumped out with their belongings to safety. The cause of the fire is under investigation.

Police are still looking into what caused the fire. Early reports point to a possible

short circuit, but officials are considering other possibilities as well.

The fire appears to have been sparked by an electric two-wheeler being charged inside the building. It spread to nearby petrol-powered two-wheelers parked in the premises, Mishra said.

Seven fire tenders and a hydraulic platform were

rushed to the spot immediately after the blaze was reported, and most residents were safely evacuated.

"Two persons, who already had health-related issues, fell ill after inhaling smoke and were shifted to the district hospital by ambulance," Mishra told reporters.

Residents recounted scenes of panic as smoke rapidly

engulfed the building following the blaze.

Arnab Singh, a 25-year-old resident living on the second floor, said that many initially did not take the incident seriously, as they believed the fire, which started after a short circuit, was confined to an electric scooter and would die down on its own.

"When smoke started billowing out, we rushed out of the building. A little later, we saw the fire spreading and realised that several petrol-powered motorcycles parked nearby had also caught fire," he said. Singh claimed there was no dedicated charging point for electric vehicles in the building and that the scooter was being charged through a regular electrical socket, which was also used to operate a water pump.

"It could have caused the short circuit that triggered the fire," he alleged.

Another resident, Ravi

Kumar Singh, said he was asleep in his room around 11.30 am when his roommate alerted him about the fire.

"Soon our room filled with smoke. We realised the blaze below had intensified and ran towards the terrace," he said.

According to him, several residents escaped by climbing onto the roof and crossing over to a neighbouring building using a ladder, as thick smoke had filled the stairways inside the building. After reaching safety, they saw that a massive fire had engulfed the parking area on the ground floor, he said.

Ravi Kumar Singh said part of the building was being used as paying guest accommodation, while the remaining portion comprised 2BHK flats rented out to families. The ground floor was being used as a parking area where residents parked their two-wheelers.

Teen dies by suicide after shooting himself in Tilak Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 17-year-old boy died by suicide after allegedly shooting himself with his father's licensed 12-bore rifle at their residence in the Tilak Nagar area around 5 pm.

Police recovered a handwritten note in which the deceased mentioned "social guilt" as the reason for taking his life. Investigators are also examining other possible factors, including emotional distress following his mother's death around two months ago, a possible relationship and his recent health issues, they said.

The incident took place on Tuesday evening at the family's rented accommodation in Chaukhandi under the Tilak Nagar police station limits in West Delhi. Police said after receiving information about the death, they rushed to the scene with a CAT ambulance, but the teenager had already been declared dead by the time they reached the house.

Preliminary enquiry revealed that the boy had recently passed class 12 and was living with his parents, a brother and two sisters. He was the youngest sibling.

According to police, the boy's father has lived in Delhi for around two decades and

earns a living by running a chole-kulche cart in Dwarka. "At the time of the incident, the boy's father and a relative were present in the house. Around 5 pm, the teenager went into the bathroom and shot himself with a 12-bore rifle," a police officer said.

The officer said family members rushed to the bathroom after hearing the gunshot but found him critically injured. Police said the weapon was originally

licensed in the name of the boy's grandfather, who had worked as a security guard. The licence was later transferred to the boy's father, who had also previously worked as a security guard at the same establishment.

Police said the arms licence is valid until 2030. A crime team examined the scene and collected forensic evidence. During the inspection, police recovered a diary containing a handwritten note; the last page referred to "social guilt", the officer said.

Police said the note mentioned a woman's name, and they are investigating.

"All possible angles are being examined, and further investigation is underway," the officer said.

Family members have also told police that the teenager had been undergoing treatment for an appendix for some time. Investigators are looking into whether his medical condition, emotional distress following his mother's death, or any other circumstances may have contributed to the incident, though no direct link has been established so far.

"No foul play is suspected at this stage," the police officer said.

Police said the body has been moved to the Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital mortuary for a postmortem.

Police said the inquest proceedings under the relevant provisions of law have been initiated.

Police are recording the statements of family members and examining the suicide note, the deceased's mobile phone and other electronic evidence as part of the ongoing investigation.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than two lakh candidates are gearing up for undergraduate admissions to the University of Delhi, with the first seat allocation list under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) set to be released on Thursday.

The first allocation list, to be announced at 5 pm on July 16, marks the beginning of seat allotment for admissions to 73 undergraduate programmes and over 150 BA programme combinations offered across 69 colleges and departments. A total of 71,624 seats are up for grabs.

According to the latest data by the university, 2,08,043 candidates have submitted their programme and college

didates mapped their CUET-UG 2026 subjects with those studied in Class 12 and filled their preferred programme and college combinations. The university had also provided a correction window, followed by the release of simulated ranks, allowing candidates to assess their likely position before making final changes to their preferences.

University officials said the most sought-after courses this year include BCom (Hons), BCom, BA (Hons) English, BA (Hons) Political Science, BA Programme (History and Political Science), BA (Hons) History, BSc (Hons) Zoology, BSc (Hons) Mathematics, BSc Programme (Life Science) and BA (Hons) Economics.



University of Delhi building



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

नीलाचल निवासाय नित्याय परमात्मने ।
बलभद्र सुभद्राभ्याम् जगन्नाथाय ते नमः ॥

महाप्रभु
श्री जगन्नाथ जी
की रथयात्रा



की हार्दिक
शुभकामनाएं



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/056/26-27

Domestic worker crushed to death by SUV in Gurugram

KHUSHI MEHROTRA ■ Gurugram

What began as a routine afternoon in Ansal Versalia, an upscale gated society in Sector 67, ended in tragedy on Wednesday when a 57-year-old domestic worker was crushed to death by a reversing SUV in the building's parking area.

Guddi, a domestic worker from Mahoba, Uttar Pradesh, had worked for a family on the fourth floor for several years. Many people in the building knew her. On Wednesday afternoon, after finishing her work, she took a break in the ground-floor parking area before heading to her next job.

Police said the incident happened between 2 pm and 2:30 pm. A resident who works as a private school teacher was parking her red Mahindra Thar and did not see Guddi resting near a pillar. The car reversed over Guddi, causing fatal injuries. Security staff and residents found Guddi unresponsive, and she was declared dead at the scene.

After the incident, domestic workers from Ansal Versalia and nearby areas gathered in the parking lot. The group began protesting, calling for action against the driver and improved safety measures. Police from Sector 67 blocked off the area, took the vehicle, and held



the driver for questioning. An FIR was filed under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita related to death by negligence. Police are reviewing CCTV footage and speaking with eyewitnesses, security staff, and residents. The Joint Commissioner of Police, Sangeeta Kalia, said the body was sent for post-mortem, and Guddi's family in Mahoba was informed.

Authorities said they will investigate whether safety rules were followed in the parking area and if the driver was careful. The incident has shown that many high-rise buildings lack designated rest areas or adequate supervision in parking areas, even though domestic workers, drivers, and delivery staff often use these spaces during work hours. Residents

said that workers often rest in basement corners and stilt parking areas to escape the heat, but this issue had not been officially discussed before.

After the protest, the Resident Welfare Association said it would hold an emergency meeting to talk about safety checks, adding speed breakers and mirrors at blind spots, and creating a special rest area for domestic workers.

"This is a wake-up call. We cannot claim to be a safe society if the people who keep it running are not safe here," said a senior RWA member. Guddi's coworkers felt her loss deeply. They remembered her sharing tiffin during festivals, helping new workers find jobs, and always being the first to arrive. Now, they are left wondering how, in a gated community with guards, cameras, and swipe-card access, a woman resting in a parking lot could go unnoticed. Guddi's death has once again highlighted the working conditions of domestic staff in Gurugram's urban villages and high-rises.

Police stated that the investigation is ongoing and further action will be taken. Police said the investigation is still going on and any further action will depend on forensic and CCTV evidence. The vehicle is still impounded, and the society has been asked to provide its parking layout and safety records.

PoJK under lockdown after deadly protests kill 12

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Jammu

Cities and towns across Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir (PoJK) are under razor-wire barricades and a heavy paramilitary presence. Rawalakot is under an undeclared media blackout ahead of a planned long march to Muzaffarabad on Wednesday. At least 12 people were killed, and dozens were injured in Tuesday's clashes as Pakistani security forces opened indiscriminate fire on protesters demanding relief from soaring prices and political reforms.

Violence broke out in Rawalakot after members of the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) ignored restrictions and began protesting.

They say the Pakistani government has ignored the region for years, kept wheat and electricity prices high, and denied them subsidies that people in other parts of the country receive.

The protests started over economic issues but quickly turned into open resistance against Islamabad's rule. Security forces used force in response. Several reports say that Rangers and police fired at the crowds, killing at least 12 civilians. Protest leaders believe the real number may be higher, as some bodies are still missing in the confusion. One Ranger was also reported killed during the clashes.

After the killings, authorities acted quickly to control the situation. Local reports say about 4,000 Rangers have been sent across PoJK, and Rawalakot is under strict lockdown. Major roads out of the town are blocked, entry and exit points are closed, and people's movement is tightly restricted. Journalists say they are not allowed into the area. Internet and mobile services have also been cut, leaving residents isolated. Despite the crackdown, activists say the protests continue.

JAAC says it will continue with Wednesday's planned march to Muzaffarabad, the capital of PoJK. Organisers expect thousands to join, hoping to reach the city and push for talks. "We have been exploited for 78



years. This time, we will not go back," a JAAC coordinator told supporters in messages sent before communications were cut.

The unrest has caught the world's attention, especially in India. Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) criticised the "excessive use of force" against civilians and pointed to what it described as years of exploitation, internet shutdowns, and blocked supplies in the disputed area. Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal called on the international community to hold Pakistan responsible for what is happening in PoJK.

People in Rawalakot are feeling both fear and determination. Reports say hospitals are full, and families have not been allowed to hold public funerals for those killed. Traders say essential goods are blocked, worsening the economic problems that sparked the protests. As Wednesday begins, PoK faces a critical moment.

"The Pakistani authorities seem set on stopping the march from reaching Muzaffarabad. But the protesters are not giving up. With security forces stationed in large numbers with clear instructions to open fire, a major confrontation could soon change the political situation in the disputed region", sources in security agencies said.

In the next few hours, it will become clear whether the authorities can stop the uprising or if their actions will only increase the anger that has been building in PoJK for years, the sources added.

Gujarat DGP reviews various facilities at Police Bhavan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Director General of Police GS Malik on Wednesday reviewed the facilities at the canteen, consumer store, gymnasium and Vatsalya Room at Police Bhavan, the headquarters of the state police, in Gandhinagar.

"State Police Chief G S Malik paid a surprise visit to various centres and offices at Police Bhavan and conducted a detailed inspection," according to an official release. He provided necessary guidance after reviewing the arrangements at the canteen, frequented by several people and police staff every day, the consumer store, the gym building and the Vatsalya Room.

"Giving utmost priority to the health of the staff and citizens, the DGP personally inspected the canteen arrangements, kitchen cleanliness, clean drinking water facility and packing dates of food items sold, etc. and gave strict suggestions to maintain quality," the release said.

Malik visited the consumer store, which operates at concessional rates for police personnel, and also suggested necessary administrative improvements.

Delhi Govt launches heat smart school pilot for students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With temperatures soaring during the summer months and posing grave danger to children, the Delhi Government on Wednesday unveiled a project Heat Smart School Pilot, showcasing innovative and scalable measures to enhance resilience against extreme heat in educational



institutions. The District Administration, Central North District, National Disaster

Management Authority (NDMA), with GIZ India hosted a high-level visit to the Heat Smart School Pilot at Sarvodaya Bal Vidyalaya, BT Block, Shalimar Bagh to showcase the unique initiative.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta congratulated all departments and partner organisations associated with the 'Heat Smart School' pilot, saying that the safety and well-being

of children is the Delhi Government's top priority. She said innovative initiatives like this are the need of the hour in the face of changing climatic conditions and expressed confidence that the model would be expanded to more schools across the Capital, playing a significant role in creating safe and climate-resilient learning environments.

FROM PAGE - 1

cluding the agreements. He expressed confidence that the partnership would promote higher trade, increased investment, innovation, and sustainable economic growth while delivering shared prosperity for India and the United Kingdom. The implementation of CETA and the Social Security Agreement marks a new phase in India-UK economic relations, with both Governments expecting the initiatives to boost bilateral trade, create employment opportunities, and strengthen long-term strategic cooperation.

US, Iran ceasefire unravels

When the US and Israel launched the war on Iran on Feb. 28, Tehran effectively closed the waterway to shipping traffic - a move that sent the price of oil, fertiliser, and many other goods soaring far beyond the region and gave Iran major leverage in negotiations. Those rising prices pose a particular challenge to US President Donald Trump and his Republican Party, which hopes to retain control of Congress in elections in November. But Washington has struggled to successfully reopen the waterway.

Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard threatened on Wednesday to halt all energy exports from the Middle East over the blockade.

"The export of oil and gas from the region will be either for everyone or for no one," it said.

The US carried out a wave of strikes, hitting dozens of targets overnight, the military's Central Command said Wednesday, and then resumed striking Iran during daylight - an unusual move that further signalled the increasing tempo of the attacks.

Within 17 hours of reimposing the blockade on Iranian ports, Central Command said US forces had "redirected" two commercial vessels attempting to run the blockade.

"The US military remains vigilant and prepared to ensure full compliance," it said on social media. Among the US military's targets was Greater Tumb Island, which is viewed as a strategic point in the Strait of Hormuz. Central Command said the attack targeted Iranian defence and missile sites.

Iran took control of three islands - Abu Musa, Greater Tumb and Lesser Tumb - from what would become the United Arab Emirates in 1971. The UAE has sought to reclaim them.

Some analysts have suggested that if the US seized the islands, it could allow it to control the strait. Another strike targeted a barracks for Iran's 388th Mechanised Infantry Brigade, which operates tanks and armoured vehicles, in Sistan and Baluchestan province, Iranian state television reported. The report said the Americans fired at least 13 missiles in the attack and that the seven dead included conscripts and career soldiers. A number of troops were wounded.

Including those at the barracks, more than 30 people have been killed in recent days, Iranian Government spokesperson Fatemeh Mohajerani said, without elaborating.

Hossein Kermanpour, a spokesperson for the Health Ministry, meanwhile, said over 260 people were wounded in overnight strikes alone - a figure far larger than for any other round of recent violence between Iran and the US. He did not say how many people were killed overnight. The army said it would make "a decisive response to this aggressive action by the American enemy," according to state TV.

Missile alert warnings sounded in Bahrain and Kuwait early Wednesday as they faced incoming Iranian fire - a daily occurrence in recent days. Jordan said it shot down three incoming Iranian missiles. Iran claimed attacks on the three nations, all of which host US forces.

US Navy Adm. Brad Cooper, who leads Central Command, said in a statement that Iran had launched dozens of missiles and drones at neighbouring Gulf Arab countries.

Trump told the Fox News Channel on Tuesday night that more US strikes against Iran would come over the next two days and that bridges and power plants could be targeted by next week unless negotiations resume. Already, the US has struck at least one bridge.

"You'd better make a deal, or you're not going to have anything left," Trump warned.

Iran's ambassador to the United Nations, Amir Saeid Iravani, criticised America's attacks.

"The US is the aggressor, not the victim," he wrote to the world body's leader, according to the state-run IRNA news agency.

The latest round of fighting is focused on the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's oil and natural gas trade passes during peacetime. How to reopen the strait has bedevilled the US since Iran choked it off in the early days of the war. (AP)

DoPT withdraws recognition of CSC

The CSC is a registered society that operates under the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) on Talkatora Road in New Delhi and was set up to promote the welfare and recreation of lower and middle-level Central Government employees. In an office memorandum issued on Tuesday by the DoPT also cited complaints of internal disputes, denial of CCTV access to DoPT nominees, unauthorised occupation of Government property, alleged gambling, unauthorised canteen, encroachments and discrimination against outsourced staff. It said these issues persisted despite the appointment of an ad hoc administrative committee in 2023 to streamline the club's functioning. The Government further said the club was no longer serving its intended purpose of staff welfare, alleging that membership had effectively become restricted and was no longer benefiting the wider community of Central Government employees.

Club officials disputed the allegations and accused the Government of seeking to take back the land on which the club stands. According to the DoPT, the club was first de-recognised in 1971 following complaints of irregularities, though recognition was restored in 1972. It was de-recognised again in 1983 after fresh complaints and was re-recognised in December 2005 following a review.

NCP-SP may back NDA over women's quota...

She said if the proposed legislation were based on a uniform 50 per cent increase in seats across all States, there would be little reason to oppose it. She, however, stressed that any decision on supporting such a proposal would be taken only after discussions within the INDIA bloc. Addressing a press conference, Sule said she was clarifying the matter after consulting NCP-SP top leadership, including party president Sharad Pawar and senior leader Jayant Patil, to avoid any misunderstanding among workers of the party and the Opposition bloc Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). The NCP-SP leader said she had also spoken to Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal, Congress leader Satej Patil and Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut on the issue.

She added that the party had not received any written proposal from the Centre regarding the delimitation exercise and, therefore, could not

take a formal stand at this stage.

Recalling earlier discussions on the issue, Sule said that after Parliament passed the Women's Reservation Bill unanimously, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju had invited her, Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Arvind Sawant and AIMIM Lok Sabha member Asaduddin Owaisi for consultations on delimitation. Union Home Minister Amit Shah was also present at the meeting, she said.

She said the Opposition had written to the Centre under the leadership of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge seeking a collective discussion on the proposal instead of holding separate consultations with individual parties.

The Union Government intends to bring the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill proposing to raise Lok Sabha seats to 850 and initiate delimitation in the Monsoon session of Parliament starting July 20.

Meanwhile, NDA Parliamentary Party meeting has been scheduled on first day of Monsoon Session on Monday in the Parliament House. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will address the MPs. The meeting is called to discuss legislative strategies and floor management ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, which spans from July 20 to August 13. The Government has also called an all party meeting on Sunday.

Madan Mitra leaves Mamata camp for rival...

Madan Mitra had been one of the oldest confidants of TMC chief and had been her companion in all the major movements even when she was the Youth Congress president.

Mitra, a popular leader who won from the Kamarhati Assembly seat even during the recent anti-TMC wave in the just concluded elections, resigned from all the party posts on Wednesday including the position of State general secretary and as the chief of all the trade union wings of the party. Curiously, Mitra, who had all these days been siding with the former CM, switched sides a day after his two sons and wife received summons from the Enforcement Directorate. Mitra was also the first TMC minister and senior to be jailed in the Sharada chit fund case.

Soon after quitting Mitra said that, he was doing so in order to breathe some fresh air. "It was quite stuffy inside. Now I am can breathe more easily," he said dumping all the responsibility of the party's debacle on TMC general secretary Abhishek Banerjee. "I had told him to quit from his post for the time being and let the others take charge but he would not. Such is his arrogance. So arrogant is he that soon after the electoral loss when we went to meet Mamata Banerjee at her residence we, including the old and senior leaders, were asked to give Abhishek a standing ovation for his effort in the elections. It was height of it all," Mitra said. When asked as to whether he felt bad about leaving Mamata Banerjee's hands the former TMC minister also said he didn't because he was in the TMC that was created by Mamata Banerjee. "It is the same TMC. I have just gone from one room to the other room," he said.

With Mitra changing sides the Mamata Banerjee faction is left with about 18 out of 80-MLAs in the Opposition ranks.

The former CM, however, downplayed the defections, stating that several leaders were switching camps out of fear of central agencies like the ED. "It is not ideology or anything else it is the fear of Central agencies that is causing the rift but don't worry we will rebuild things as more such defections are engineered the more sympathy we will get from the people," she said.

CCEA approves ₹25,445 crore elevated corridors for Varanasi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) on Tuesday approved two major elevated corridor projects worth ₹25,445.96 crore for Varanasi, aimed at easing traffic congestion, improving multimodal connectivity and significantly reducing travel time.

The two projects will be implemented under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) and form a key part of the Varanasi Decongestion Plan.

The first project approved by the CCEA is 46.039 km , comprising a six-lane elevated main carriageway, an iconic cable-stayed bridge, an extradosed Foot Over Bridge-cum-Major Bridge, loops, ramps, link roads and service roads, will be implemented under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) at a total capital cost of ₹14,447.64 crore including a civil construction cost of ₹6,037.85 crore (including utility shifting, excluding GST) and a land acquisition cost of ₹541.11 crore under NH(O).

The project will provide seamless connectivity between NH-19 and the Varanasi Ring Road, significantly decongesting the city's road network and improving urban mobility.

Designed for an operating speed of 80–100 km/h, it is expected to reduce the average travel time across the project influence area from approximately 60 minutes to 20 minutes, representing a reduction of nearly 67 per cent.

Travel time between NH-19 and Kashi Railway Station will be reduced from approximately 50 minutes to about 25 minutes, resulting in a saving of about 25 minutes (nearly 50 per cent).

Aligned with the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan, the corridor will strengthen multimodal connectivity by



providing seamless access to major highways, railway stations, Lal Bahadur Shastri Airport and Ramnagar IWAI Port, while significantly improving connectivity to key religious, educational and cultural landmarks, including the Kashi Vishwanath Temple, Banaras Hindu University (BHU), Namohat, Ramnagar Fort and the Ghats of Varanasi.

By linking important economic, social and logistics nodes, the project will improve logistics efficiency, enhance road safety, facilitate tourism and pilgrimage, and support sustainable regional economic growth across eastern Uttar Pradesh.

The corridor has been conceived as a transformative urban mobility project to decongest the road network of Varanasi & Chandauli by providing a high-speed, access-controlled connection between NH-19, the Varanasi Ring Road (NH-135B), Ramnagar/ BHU and other major urban destinations.

With more than 15 crore tourists and pilgrims visiting Varanasi every year, the project will significantly improve connectivity to major religious, educational and cultural landmarks, including the Kashi Vishwanath Temple, Banaras Hindu University (BHU), Namohat,

Ramnagar Fort, the Ghats of Varanasi, and Kashi Railway Station, while substantially reducing congestion on the existing city road network.

An elevated spur between BHU/Lanka and Samne Ghat will further ease traffic congestion at the heavily trafficked Lanka Junction by separating through traffic from local traffic movements.

The project will improve road safety through controlled-access movement, reduce vehicle operating costs and emissions, enhance travel reliability, and facilitate the efficient movement of passenger and freight traffic.

It will also decongest NH-19, the BHU-Ramnagar Corridor and NH-35 by diverting through traffic away from the densely developed urban core.

The project comprises a 6/4-lane predominantly elevated corridor, including main carriageway, flyovers, loops, ramps and service roads, and will be implemented by the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) at a total capital cost of ₹10,998.32 crore, including a civil construction cost of ₹4,565.33 crore and land acquisition cost of ₹934.91 crore.

The corridor is a major component of the Varanasi Decongestion Plan and will

provide seamless connectivity between NH-31 and Kashi Railway Station, while substantially improving access to Varanasi Ring Road, Varanasi Airport, Kashi Railway Station, Varanasi City Railway Station, Varanasi Junction, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Junction, Ramnagar Port, Sampurnanand Sanskrit University, the ghats of Varanasi and the adjoining Chandauli region.

Designed for an operating speed of 80–100 km/h, the project will reduce travel time between NH-31 and Kashi Railway Station from approximately 40 minutes to 20 minutes, representing a reduction of nearly 50 per cent.

It will significantly decongest the city's road network, improve road safety, reduce vehicle operating costs and facilitate faster, uninterrupted movement of passenger and freight traffic.

The project will also strengthen regional connectivity by improving access to one Economic Node (Chandauli Social Economic Zone), one Social Node (Chandauli) and six major Logistics Nodes, thereby enhancing multimodal integration in line with the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan.

It will facilitate efficient movement of agricultural produce, industrial goods, construction materials and minerals, improving logistics efficiency and supporting sustainable economic growth across eastern Uttar Pradesh.

Overall, the project will create a modern, access-controlled urban transport corridor that enhances connectivity, strengthens multimodal transport integration, promotes tourism and economic development, and improves the quality of life for residents and visitors to Varanasi.

Punjab: Farmers take out motorcycle marches against India-US trade deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh/Hoshiarpur

Protesting against the proposed India-US trade deal, farmers took out motorcycle marches in Punjab on Wednesday, alleging that it would adversely impact the country's farming sector.

The marches were carried out on a call given by different farming bodies under the banner of 'Desh Bachao Morcha' in Punjab.

Several farmers' organisations, including Kisan Mazdoor Morcha, Samyukt Kisan Morcha (Non-Political), Azad Kisan Morcha, Bharatiya Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Organisation and BKU (Boka Singh Mansa), participated in the motorcycle marches.

Opposing the India-US trade deal, farmer leaders claimed that the pact is not limited to the import and export of a few products. Instead, it may cover several crucial sectors, including agriculture, dairy, digital trade, services, intellectual property rights, energy and investment.

Highlighting the United States' long demand for greater access to India's agriculture and dairy sectors, they said any reduction in import duties on agricultural and dairy products could adversely affect Indian farmers, dairy producers and

small industries.

The leaders pointed out that the complete text of the agreement has not yet been made public, leading to widespread concern among sections of society.

They emphasised that such a significant and sensitive agreement should be placed before the people and discussed thoroughly in Parliament.

As part of the call, a motorcycle march was taken out by the Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Committee (Piddi Group) in Hoshiarpur. Led by the outfit's district president Paramjit Singh Bhulla and district general secretary Kuldip Singh Begowal, the march commenced after an 'ardas' (prayer) at Gurdwara Pull Pukhta Sahib near Tanda and passed through Tanda, Dasuya and Miani.

The protesters later reached the office of Dasuya Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) Kanwaljit Singh and submitted a memorandum addressed to the prime minister, demanding the immediate withdrawal of the proposed India-US trade agreement.

In the memorandum, the protesters alleged that the proposed trade pact would adversely affect farmers, agricultural labourers, livestock rearers, small traders and micro industries.



Workers under the 'Desh Bachao Morcha' take out a motorcycle rally against the proposed India-US trade deal and Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), while heading to the Deputy Commissioner's office to submit a memorandum in Amritsar, Punjab on Wednesday

Nation Focus



PURI GEARS UP FOR RAINY RATH YATRA AMID TIGHT SECURITY

The three chariots of Lord Jagannath and his sibling deities are ready to roll along Puri's Grand Road on Thursday as the Odisha government braces for the attendance of lakhs of devotees for a possibly rain-soaked Rath Yatra.

The temple town has been blanketed by a multi-layered security cover with the deployment of personnel from state police, central forces, Indian Navy and Coast Guard, while special focus is on crowd control, traffic management and emergency response.

Puri received a staggering 143.8 mm of rain on the eve of the iconic chariot festival and has battened down the hatches for heavy showers on Thursday as the weather department issued a red warning for heavy showers and thunderstorms.



ED FILES CHARGESHEET IN ₹40 LAKH US VISA FRAUD CASE

Private immigration assistance agencies from some north Indian states allegedly used to deposit ₹40 lakh in the bank accounts of US visa aspirants for a "short duration" to create "false" financial credentials for them to obtain the vital travel authorisation, the ED has said in a latest chargesheet.

The federal agency filed a prosecution complaint (chargesheet) on Monday before a special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court in Jalandhar in a case related to "organised" immigration and visa fraud.

The ED probe stems from multiple FIRs filed by the Delhi Police and the Punjab Police against this alleged racket that was prompted by a complaint filed by the US Embassy in Delhi, the agency said in a statement on Wednesday.

Ladakh flags off first 5 MT apricot consignment to UAE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In a landmark initiative that would transform Ladakh's horticulture sector and expand international market access for local farmers, Lieutenant Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena, Wednesday flagged off the first export consignment of 5 MT of Ladakh's premium apricots to the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

The initiative marks the beginning of Ladakh's largest-ever fresh apricot export programme and is expected to significantly enhance farmers' incomes while establishing Ladakh as a global supplier of premium-quality organic apricots.

Speaking on the occasion, L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena said that the export of the first consignment marked the beginning of a new era for Ladakh's horticulture sector and reflected the Administration's commitment to connecting local farmers directly with global markets.



ment to connecting local farmers directly with global markets.

"This export initiative is a historic moment for Ladakh, its horticulture sector and, above all, our hardworking farmers. The flagging off of the first export consignment of Ladakh apricots to the UAE marks the beginning of Ladakh's journey towards becoming a global horticultural export hub.

This initiative will not

only provide our farmers with direct access to international markets but also ensure fair and remunerative prices for their produce, substantially improving their incomes and living conditions," said L-G Saxena.

The export has been facilitated under an MoU signed in April 2026 between the Ladakh Administration and the UAE-based global retail conglomerate Lulu Retail through APEDA, which

envisages the export of over 1,000 metric tonnes of fresh apricots during the current harvest season.

According to a statement of the DIPR, Ladakh, "This is a monumental leap from the mere 1,500 KG of apricots exported during the previous two years, making it one of the most significant milestones in Ladakh's horticultural history".

Apricots, being fragile and perishable, require to be stored and transported in temperatures from zero degrees to 4 degrees. Keeping this in view, the Ladakh Administration, with support from CONCOR, ensured the shipment of Apricots from Ladakh using cold-chain transportation so as to maintain the freshness of the fruits.

The flagship export initiative focuses on 'Raktsey Karpo' and 'Halman', Ladakh's indigenous apricot varieties, internationally recognised for their exceptional sweetness, rich

flavour, superior nutritional value and completely organic cultivation. Grown under Ladakh's unique high-altitude climatic conditions, abundant sunshine and pristine environment, the variety is regarded among the finest apricots in the world and has witnessed increasing demand in international markets.

Notably, the farmers had traditionally faced considerable challenges in harvesting, sorting, grading, cleaning, packaging and marketing their produce, often resulting in significant post-harvest losses and reduced returns. But under the new arrangement with Lulu Retail, farmers would simply hand over their orchards to the export agency at the time of harvest, following which the company would undertake the entire value chain – from plucking, sorting to grading, processing, packaging and transporting it to international markets.

HC grants relief for TMC martyrs' day rally

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

After days of tug-of-war between rival groups of the Trinamool Congress demanding police permission for the premium Victoria House venue near the busy Esplanade crossing to hold their respective version of the TMC Martyrs' Day rally the Mamata Banerjee faction of the party on Wednesday managed to receive a "face saving" relief from the Calcutta High which directed the administration to accommodate the former Chief Minister's rally near Birla Planetarium, some two km south of Victoria House where the former Chief Minister had been holding her rally every year for the past 15 years or so.

The Bench of Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya shifted the venue from Victoria House to Cathedral Road in front of Birla Planetarium after the State Government cited traffic disruption in the heart of Kolkata and law and order issues if the two rival



factions were allowed to hold rallies near each other.

After hearing senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee appearing for the Mamata Banerjee faction the Court granted permission allowed the group hold its rally but with not more than 3,000 people attending. The Court also restricted the rally timing between 12.30 and 3.30 pm asking the organisers to submit the names of at least 20 volunteers who would be responsible for maintaining order to the Kolkata Police.

The other faction led by State Opposition Leader

Ritabarta Bannerjee has already been given a permission by the Kolkata Police to hold its own version of rally on Mayo Road near the Mahatma Gandhi Statue little more than a km away Victoria House.

The Congress which also organizes its own version of Martyrs' Day rally was earlier allowed to hold the meeting at Shahid Minar not very far away from Victoria House crossing. Incidentally, in a smart move apparently towards bringing the two outfits closer, particularly when Mamata Banerjee needed it the most the Pradesh Congress for the first time invited the former Chief Minister to attend its rally at Shahid Minar.

TMC Martyrs' Day rally is held every year since 1993 to commemorate 14 Youth Congress workers who died in a police firing on July 21 during a skirmish between a rally led by Mamata Banerjee then a Youth Congress leader and the police force.

Punjab Police foils a terror attack just before Prime Minister's visit

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Amritsar

Amritsar Commissionerate Police foiled a cross-border terror plot, arresting one suspect and recovering a hand grenade, a 9 mm Glock pistol, and four live cartridges. The police action is believed to have averted potential violence and ensured public order in the sensitive border district.

The arrest happened just before Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Punjab on July 17.

He is slated to launch several railway infrastructure projects and other development programs.

Security agencies have heightened vigilance in Amritsar and nearby areas in preparation for the visit, which is expected to draw large crowds.

Punjab Police said the

recovery of weapons highlights the seriousness of the conspiracy.

"Preliminary investigation reveals that the accused was in contact with cross-border ISI handlers through Instagram and was being directed to target police establishments and public places to disturb peace and public order. Punjab Police remains vigilant and committed to dismantling terror networks," DGP Punjab Gaurav Yadav said.

Investigators think the goal was to spread fear and disrupt peace in the area. The hand grenade and loaded Glock pistol show a clear plan to use violence.

Police officials said the seizure happened just in time and was important in stopping a possible attack.

An FIR has been filed at Police Station Cantonment, Amritsar, under the laws



about terrorism and illegal weapons.

The suspect is in custody, and police are still questioning him to learn more about the plan.

They are also continuing to analyse the communication records.

Senior police officials said

they are still investigating to uncover the entire network, identify other people involved in India, and determine who the handlers are on the other side of the border.

Specialised agencies are analysing the suspect's phone, social media, and

other communication records. Social media is often used to radicalise and direct people inside India.

This case shows how handlers now use encrypted or seemingly harmless platforms to issue instructions while staying hidden.

Constant monitoring and quick response have helped neutralise several such conspiracies in recent times.

Amritsar, being a sensitive border district with significant religious and tourist footfall, remains under heightened security vigil.

Residents and security analysts alike have welcomed the successful bust as a timely intervention that has saved potential lives. Investigators are also examining whether the accused had any prior criminal record or links with other modules.

Police are looking into

the accused's finances and travel history.

Punjab Police have asked people to stay alert and report anything suspicious or strange messages on social media to the nearest police station.

Officials said that public help is key to keeping the state safe.

As the investigation continues, police are confident they will uncover the full plan and catch everyone involved.

This operation shows that the Punjab Police are committed to keeping people safe from cross-border threats.

Lok Sabha tells MPs to avoid smart watches, spectacles in Parliament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha secretariat has advised the MPs not to use smart watches, or smart spectacles in ways that may compromise the security, privileges and privacy of members in the Parliament Estate during the upcoming Monsoon Session.

The Monsoon Session of Parliament is slated to begin July 20, and will continue till August 13.

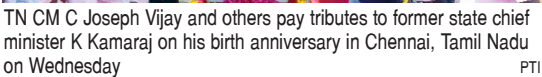
"Members are aware that a large number of advanced devices such as smart spectacles/ pen cameras/ smart watches etc. are now widely available in the country. Some of these devices can be used in ways so as to compromise privacy of Members and



breach parliamentary privileges," a bulletin issued by the Lok Sabha secretariat on Wednesday said.

In view of this, MPs were requested to refrain from using such devices in any way that compromises security, privileges and privacy of members in any part of the Parliament Estate, the secretariat said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A Booth Level Officer (BLO) verifies voter details during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls at Karad in Satara district, Maharashtra on Wednesday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 Bhopal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu during the inauguration of 'Saushrutam 2026' at the All India Institute of Ayurveda (AIIA), New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi



Doctors said a key factor behind its success was selective lung ventilation, in which the anaesthesia team ventilated one lung while allowing the other to remain still for surgery – a highly demanding technique in infants because of their tiny airways.

Flood situation in Arunachal worsens, over 1 lakh affected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

The flood situation in Arunachal Pradesh worsened on Wednesday, with 26 of the State's 28 districts affected and the number of people hit by the deluge crossing one lakh, an official bulletin said.

The rain-triggered floods and landslides have so far claimed seven lives and injured 29 people across the State, said the bulletin issued by the State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC).

Upper Subansiri, Upper Siang, Kra Daadi, Kamle and Papum Pare were the districts that reported fresh flood and landslide incidents over the last 24 hours.

In Upper Subansiri, floods and landslides affected Limeking, Nacho, Siyum and Daporijo circles.

Upper Siang reported fresh damage in Mariyang, Yingkiong, Palling and Jengging circles. Fresh incidents were also reported from Tali circle in Kra Daadi district, Raga circle in Kamle district and Kimin circle in Papum Pare district.

During the last 24 hours, Upper Subansiri recorded three flood incidents and three landslides, while Upper Siang witnessed 15 land-



slides, seven heavy rainfall incidents and four floods.

Kra Daadi reported two landslides, while Kamle and Papum Pare recorded one flood incident each.

The SEOC said 250 more people were affected in Upper Subansiri, taking the cumulative number of flood-hit people in the state to 1,03,167 across 306 circles and 485 villages.

Upper Siang remained the worst-affected district with 49,259 people impacted, followed by Siang (25,365), Kra Daadi (13,731), East Kameng (6,146), Upper Subansiri (3,467) and Namsai (2,657).

According to the bulletin, 622 houses have been damaged across the State, including 454 kutchu houses, 100 pucca houses, 44 huts and 24 other structures.

Among the fresh losses reported, a kutchu house was completely destroyed in Kra Daadi due to a landslide, while another was severely damaged in Kamle following flooding.

Infrastructure damage was also reported in several districts. In Upper Subansiri, floods damaged a bridge in Limeking circle, besides roads, a flood protection wall and a retaining wall at Rapenrijo, while landslides damaged roads in Rakmi and Jingmuri villages.

In Upper Siang, floods and landslides damaged retaining walls, water supply systems, flood protection structures and minor irrigation infrastructure at several locations.

Kra Daadi reported damage to two schools, a

hostel and a boundary wall due to landslides, while floodwaters damaged a minor irrigation structure in Upper Sher village of Papum Pare district.

The cumulative damage to agriculture and horticulture has risen to 561.75 hectares, including 224 hectares of agricultural land and 337.75 hectares of horticulture plantations.

Meanwhile, the IMD has forecast thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and heavy to very heavy rainfall in parts of the state on Thursday, with isolated areas of Papum Pare likely to receive 12-20 cm of rainfall in 24 hours.

On Friday, East Kameng and Papum Pare districts are expected to receive very heavy rainfall, while Changlang is likely to witness heavy rain accompanied by thunderstorms and lightning.

Weather conditions are expected to improve from Saturday, though East Kameng, Kurung Kumey, Papum Pare and Changlang will remain under a heavy rainfall alert.

By Sunday, only Papum Pare is expected to remain under watch for heavy rain, while no significant weather warning has been issued for Monday.

Assam to draft SOP on human-wildlife conflict

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

In a major bid to resolve the escalating ecological crisis, the Assam Government has initiated a comprehensive consultative process to develop a scientific and sustainable strategy for managing human-wildlife conflict across the State, with a particular focus on the human-elephant conflict and the rising monkey menace.

This was announced by Assam Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Jayanta Mallabaruah, following a high-level meeting with Members of the Legislative Assembly (MLAs), senior forest officials, and key stakeholders at the Assam Legislative Assembly campus in Dispur. The discussions aimed to identify region-specific interventions, bolster inter-agency coordination, and draft a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP).

Highlighting the gravity of the human-elephant conflict, Mallabaruah revealed that nearly 150 human lives are lost annually in the State due to encounters with elephants. Apart from the loss of life, wild herds cause extensive damage to agricultural crops and rural livelihoods.

According to the Minister, the long-term solution lies in massive afforestation drives to enhance forest cover and build natural habitats for ele-



(L to R) MK Yadava, IFS, Special Chief Secretary (Forest), Jayanta Mallabaruah, Minister for Finance, Forest & Environment, etc, L to L Government of Assam, Atul Bora, Minister for P&RD, Excise, etc., Government of Assam during the meeting at Assam Legislative Assembly Conference Hall, Dispur

phants. The Government is exploring dedicated plantations of tree species that serve as natural food sources, reducing the animals' dependency on agricultural fields.

Under a new scientific mapping approach, the State has been divided into distinct "elephant management zones" based on herd populations and migratory patterns rather than administrative boundaries. Dedicated consultations will be held within each zone, involving local MLAs, wildlife experts, and forest officers to customise regional interventions, such as solar fencing and bio-fencing. The Minister cautioned that the indiscriminate installation of solar fences often merely diverts herds into adjacent localities without addressing the core crisis.

The State Government is

also exploring the use of aerial seeding in difficult, inaccessible terrains where conventional plantation drives are not feasible. Forest Battalions, the Armed Forces, and local institutions will be roped in for these afforestation programmes.

Addressing the monkey menace, which has severely hit agriculture and horticulture across several districts, Mallabaruah stated that the Government is examining humane, scientific interventions. Among these is a proposed animal sterilisation programme. Drawing on successful models from other States, the Government is assessing the feasibility of specialised veterinary mobile units, operating facilities, and dedicated transport. However, any sterilisation programme will only be

implemented after extensive public consultation and constituency-level assessments by local MLAs, the Minister added.

To ease the distress of the affected families, the Government is simultaneously streamlining the compensation mechanism. Dedicated funds will be placed with District Commissioners to facilitate immediate, hassle-free disbursement of financial relief following verification. This expedited process will cover crop damage and loss of life caused by elephants, tigers, and other wild animals.

All stakeholders have been requested to submit their written recommendations by 20 or 21 July. Based on these inputs, the Forest Department aims to ready the final comprehensive SOP by 22 July.

Mob attacks Assam Rifles camp in Manipur

TONY DAS
■ Imphal

An unruly mob targeted an Assam Rifles camp in Manipur's Senapati town on the night of 14-15 July, resorting to stone-pelting, arson, and vandalism, defence officials said on Wednesday.

The violence erupted following an area domination patrol and search operation launched by the Assam Rifles. The operation was initiated based on credible intelligence inputs regarding the presence of armed cadres in the Makuilongdi area, located about two kilometres west of a designated NSCN (IM) camp at Oklong.

Intelligence reports and social media updates had indicated that armed cadres were moving outside their designated camps, carrying weapons and wearing uniforms in blatant violation of the established Ceasefire Ground Rules. The Ceasefire Monitoring Group (CFMG) was formally apprised of the security concerns and rule violations.

During the security operation, Assam Rifles columns approaching Makuilongdi and Oklong villages were obstructed by local residents, including women. Maintaining maximum



restraint, the security personnel held discussions with local representatives, assuring them that the operation was aimed solely at maintaining peace and that forces would not enter any village without official consent.

However, tensions escalated by 9:00 pm as a large crowd gathered in Senapati town and began marching towards the Assam Rifles camp. Despite the withdrawal of the patrolling columns, the violent mob reached the camp around 9:30 pm, pelting stones, damaging property, and attempting arson.

Security forces, in coordination with the Manipur Police, deployed minimal force, firing blank rounds and tear-gas grenades to disperse the crowd and prevent further escalation. Senapati Police and the Central Reserve

Police Force (CRPF) were immediately deployed to restore law and order.

While retreating, sections of the mob vandalised security vehicles, setting a light vehicle ablaze and overturning two trucks. A civilian car was also reportedly burnt during the ruckus.

Coordinated efforts by the security forces, State police, and the CRPF brought the situation under control, fully dispersing the crowd by midnight.

Officials confirmed that the situation in Senapati is currently peaceful and under control, with no injuries or casualties reported on either side. Security forces and district authorities have initiated dialogues with Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) to maintain communal harmony and address local concerns.

Isha Gramotsavam sports fest expands to 10 States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Coimbatore

In a major boost to grassroots sports, Isha Gramotsavam, India's largest annual rural sports festival, is set to expand its footprint to northern Indian States for its 18th edition. Organised by Sadhguru's Isha Outreach, the tournament will now span 10 States and one Union Territory, making this the largest-ever chapter of the rural sporting event.

For the first time, the tournament—historically a highly anticipated fixture across rural southern India—will be conducted in Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Odisha, and Maharashtra, alongside Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and Puducherry.

The mega-event is projected to bring together more than 80,000 players from over 40,000 villages, forming an estimated 7,000 teams. Notably, the edition will see the participation of nearly 15,000 women players.

The tournament boasts a total prize pool of over ₹1



crore, designed to keep grassroots players highly motivated. While men will compete in volleyball, women will face off in throwball. The winning teams in both categories at the Grand Finale will receive ₹5 lakh each, while the runners-up will be awarded ₹3 lakh. Third and fourth-place teams will walk away with ₹1 lakh and ₹50,000, respectively.

Cash prizes will also be handed out during the Cluster and Divisional stages. Furthermore, the festival features dedicated awards for the Paralympic category, reinforcing its commitment

to inclusive sports.

"With every edition, Isha Gramotsavam continues to grow not just in scale but in impact," said Swami Pulaka, Gramotsavam Coordinator. "By intentionally excluding professional athletes, the tournament creates a rare opportunity for village players to experience structured competition and showcase their abilities on a national platform."

The competition features a multi-stage format comprising cluster-level matches, divisional rounds, and the Grand Finale. The matches have already commenced.

Manipur CM promises normalcy



Manipur CM Y Khemchand Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh on Wednesday asserted that his Government was committed to restoring normalcy, ensuring public safety and facilitating the free movement of all communities along the State's national highways.

He made the remarks during a visit to Kanto Sabal village in Imphal West district, where at least three houses were recently set ablaze by a mob.

Singh urged people of the area to uphold peace and harmony, saying those were the foundation for the State's progress.

During the visit, he also inspected the reconstruc-

tion of the houses damaged in the arson incident.

He said infrastructure, education and healthcare could flourish only in a peaceful environment, calling upon all sections of society to work together for the State's inclusive growth and prosperity.

Singh said the Government was making every effort to ensure the free movement of all communities along the national highways passing through Manipur.

The Village Development Committee of Kanto Sabal, along with local Meira Paibis and representatives of village clubs, submitted a memorandum to the chief minister highlighting local issues and security concerns.

BJP to hold protest on July 17 against Bidadi project



BJP State chief BY Vijayendra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ballari (Karnataka)

The BJP on Wednesday said it would stage a day-long sit-in protest on July 17 against the proposed GBT project near Bidadi in Bengaluru South district.

The party also alleged that Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar was "prioritising real estate over the interests of farmers."

Addressing a press conference, BJP State chief BY Vijayendra said, "On July 17, BJP MLAs, MPs, former MLAs, and former MPs will stage a day-long sit-in protest at Freedom Park in Bengaluru. We demand the withdrawal of cases against agitating farmers and the scrapping of the Bidadi Township project."

ECI ready for One Nation One Election with 6-month notice, says Parliament panel chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Election Commission, in its preliminary submission to the Joint Committee of Parliament on the proposed 'One Nation One Election', has said it would be ready to conduct simultaneous Lok Sabha and assembly elections if given six months' notice, panel chairman PP Chaudhary said on Wednesday.

Chaudhary was speaking to the media after the committee concluded its three-day consultations with academia.

Responding to a question, Chaudhary said that the committee would also hear the EC before finalising its recommendations on the proposed constitutional amendments.

"We will hear the Election Commission on how it plans to conduct 'One Nation One Election'. We will put our questions to it, and only after hearing its views will the committee recommend whether it is feasible or not," he said.

Referring to EC's submission, he said, "The poll body had indicated that simulta-



Parliament panel chairman PP Chaudhary

neous elections across the country would be feasible if it is given six months' advance notice."

"The Election Commission believes that if Parliament passes the law in 2028, it can conduct 'One Nation One Election' from 2029," he reiterated.

Describing the proposal as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, Chaudhary said simultaneous Lok Sabha and assembly elections had been conducted in the country between 1954 and 1960 using ballot papers.

"We cannot underestimate our voters. They are politically aware and capable of deciding whom to vote for. That is why India's democracy enjoys a distinct

place in the world," he said. Constitutional experts who appeared before the panel had opined that the proposal did not violate the basic structure of the Constitution, federalism or democracy, he said.

"It is only a timetable for holding Lok Sabha and assembly elections together. It does not curtail the powers or rights of the states," he quoted the experts.

Claiming broad public support for the proposal, Chaudhary said, "Almost 99 per cent of civil society and ordinary people are in favour of 'One Nation One Election'. This is the will of the people."

He said stakeholders had told the committee that fre-

quent elections disrupted governance as officials were repeatedly diverted for poll duty across states.

Earlier, the committee examining the Constitution (Amendment) Bills on the proposed One Nation One Election initiative held discussions with vice-chancellors, directors and heads of departments from leading universities and institutions in Uttar Pradesh, including Dr Ram Manohar Lohiya National Law University, Banaras Hindu University, Indian Institute of Information Technology, Kanpur, Indian Institute of Management Lucknow and the University of Allahabad.

According to an official statement, the participants made detailed presentations covering various provisions of the proposed constitutional amendment Bills.

The discussions focused on issues such as Centre-State relations, the implications of mid-term elections, the concept of an unexpired term, the long-term sustainability of simultaneous elections, the proposed powers of the Election Commission of India and other aspects of electoral reforms.

Wayanad landslide: Govt ensured quick relief, says CM Satheesan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Wednesday said the State Government had effectively carried out rescue, relief and rehabilitation measures following the recent Wayanad landslide and praised the ministers and the district administration for their coordinated efforts.

Replying to questions at a press conference, Satheesan said all the work to be undertaken by the Government in the aftermath of the disaster had been carried out effectively.

He commended Revenue Minister AP Anil Kumar and Agriculture Minister T Siddique for their work in Wayanad following the landslide.

The CM said that, unlike in many disaster situations where search operations are wound up after some time, authorities in Wayanad continued the efforts until all eight bodies were recovered.

He said special arrangements were made for the relatives of victims who had come from outside the State, and the Government facili-



tated the transportation of the bodies, including by arranging a special aircraft. Satheesan said rehabilitation measures had been initiated in the affected area and all residents living in identified danger zones had been shifted to safer places.

He said ministers had held discussions with the Konkan Railway authorities and its subsidiary, which carried out work at the landslide site, to coordinate further measures related to the disaster.

The CM said the Government had also reached an understanding under which, in addition to the compensation announced by the State, the company concerned would

provide additional compensation to the victims.

"All these activities were carried out efficiently under the leadership of the ministers and the district administration," he said.

Asked why Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra had not visited the landslide site, Satheesan said both leaders were out of station and therefore could not travel to Wayanad.

Eight people were killed and several others injured in a landslide on July 7 at the site of the Anakkompoyil-Meppadi tunnel project, which is intended to improve connectivity between Wayanad and Kozhikode districts.



Editor's
TAKE

India and Britain’s trade deal finally gets real

The India–UK Trade Agreement came into force on July 15, and the real test of whether it lives up to its billing as a ‘gold standard’ pact now begins

Trade deals are easy to sign and hard to deliver. India and Britain took three years and more than fourteen negotiating rounds to reach an agreement in 2025; they now have to prove that the paperwork translates into shipments, jobs and investment. From Wednesday, roughly 99 per cent of India’s tariff lines will enter the UK duty-free, while India begins dismantling tariffs on about 90 per cent of British goods. A parallel Double Contribution Convention will spare workers on short assignments from paying social security contributions twice – a small but real win for India’s mobile professionals. The gains look genuine and impressive, but they have to be implemented in the right earnest.

Labour-intensive Indian sectors – textiles, leather, footwear, marine products, gems and jewellery – get immediate duty-free entry into a market where they previously paid tariffs of 4-16 per cent. That is meaningful for employment-heavy industries in states such as Tamil Nadu, Gujarat and Punjab. Britain, in turn, gets a foothold for Scotch whisky, whose Indian duty falls from 150 per cent to 75 per cent immediately and to 40 per cent within a decade, along with phased openings for automobiles, machinery and financial services.

London’s own estimates put the long-run boost to UK GDP at roughly £4.8 billion – modest in percentage terms, but the Government calls it Britain’s most significant bilateral deal since Brexit. The nuances matter as much as the numbers. India’s own tariff cuts are staggered over years, even as Indian exporters gain near-immediate access to the UK – a sequencing that favours Indian industry’s adjustment window. Automobiles are capped by tight quotas, meaning the celebrated UK carmakers’ win is really a boutique privilege for a handful of luxury brands rather than a mass-market opening. Sensitive items on both sides - dairy, apples, sugar, gold and smartphones – remain largely untouched, a reminder that “comprehensive” still leaves room for domestic politics.

The pitfalls deserve equal billing. Civil society groups under the Forum for Trade Justice have warned that CETA leans on voluntary rather than compulsory licensing for medicines, a shift that could complicate India’s public health flexibilities under WTO rules. Digital trade provisions that limit India’s ability to demand source code access for imported software have drawn similar unease over regulatory and security sovereignty. On the UK side, farm groups worry that Indian antimicrobial-use standards could undercut British livestock producers who have spent years reducing antibiotic use.

And non-tariff friction – Britain’s tightening steel regime, its carbon border tax, and rules of origin that Indian MSMEs are still learning to navigate – could blunt gains that look impressive on paper. CETA’s success, in other words, will be decided less by the signing euphoria than by the unglamorous machinery of implementation: customs registration, origin certification, and whether both governments actually help exporters use the access they have won. July 15 is a beginning, not a verdict.

Uttar Pradesh: Can the BJP hold its bastion?

With Uttar Pradesh once again emerging as the country’s principal political battleground, the contest is shaping up as a test not only of competing campaign strategies but also of contrasting visions for India’s future



KALYANI SHANKAR

With the UP elections drawing closer, the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is rolling out a comprehensive, strategic plan aimed not only at retaining power in the state but also at solidifying its influence across India.

The strategy emphasises uniting the NDA and addressing local issues that resonate with voters. Still, it would benefit from detailing how the BJP plans to tailor its messages to specific caste and regional concerns to demonstrate a nuanced understanding of voter diversity.

The BJP has identified 100 constituencies as particularly important for electoral success, but including the criteria or process used to select them would clarify how these priorities were determined and their significance.

The party plans to appoint local organisers known as booth palaks, who will energise grassroots engagement, making voters feel that their concerns are valued and understood, and booth pravasis, who will facilitate outreach and mobilisation efforts.

These local representatives will play a crucial role in liaising with residents, understanding their concerns, and ensuring that the party’s messages resonate effectively within their communities.

The party plans to launch extensive social media campaigns and targeted advertisements to reach diverse demographics, with tailored digital strategies designed to inspire confidence in the campaign’s effectiveness across regions and age groups.

The BJP is promoting a message of inclusive development. The party is committed to supporting various demographic groups, particularly farmers and women. The schemes launched would benefit farmers and women’s self-help groups, uplifting these communities.

Nationalism remains a cornerstone of the BJP’s identity and messaging.

The party seeks to project itself as a guardian of national interests, particularly regarding national security. By emphasising robust defence policies and a strong stance on terrorism and internal security, the BJP aims to resonate with voters who favour a strong, secure government. This approach seeks to galvanise support by appealing to citizens’ desire for protective leadership that adequately addresses threats.

The economy will also be a focal point of the BJP’s campaign. The party intends to showcase its efforts to revive the economy, with particular emphasis on job creation initiatives.



THE COALITION IS FOCUSED ON MAKING AYODHYA CENTRAL TO ITS ASSEMBLY ELECTION CAMPAIGN, SEEKING TO USE ALLEGED DONATION IRREGULARITIES TO CHALLENGE THE BJP’S CLAIM OF BEING THE SOLE DEFENDER OF HINDU INTERESTS

The writer is a popular columnist

Programmes such as the Production-Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme, which aims to incentivise domestic manufacturing and attract investment, will be highlighted.

The messaging will aim to reassure voters, especially young people, that the BJP can stimulate economic growth and create employment opportunities.

In addition, the BJP is preparing to robustly counter any opposition criticism of its governance. The strategy includes demonstrating that the Opposition is fragmented and lacks a coherent governance plan. By drawing sharp contrasts between its own successes and the failures of opposing parties, the BJP seeks to bolster its image as an effective and reliable party.

While the BJP stands as a formidable national presence, it also recognises the importance of building local alliances. The party is likely to seek partnerships with regional and smaller political parties to enhance its electoral prospects, fostering hope that such cooperation will strengthen governance and community representation.

The BJP’s strategy for the upcoming elections emphasises clear communication, community engagement, national security and economic recovery.

The party aims to address voters’ concerns and has developed an “election-ready” framework that strengthens grassroots outreach and booth-level committees while incorporating more young people and women into its leadership.

Poll-bound states, including Uttar Pradesh, have been instructed to prepare for potential early elections.

The Opposition in Uttar Pradesh is gearing up for the upcoming elections with a concerted effort. Around 23 parties have united under the INDIA coalition, aiming to present a formidable challenge to the ruling Bharatiya

Janata Party (BJP).

The Opposition is preparing for the polls with a clear five-point strategy. This strategy focuses on important issues that matter to voters, such as unemployment, economic inequality and social justice. By emphasising these topics, the Opposition hopes to show that it cares about the needs of ordinary citizens and to set itself apart from the ruling party.

The Opposition emphasises grassroots engagement and is maximising its efforts. Local leaders and representatives from various parties are mobilising to connect with voters directly, understand their concerns, and present a united front against the BJP. This engagement strategy includes town hall meetings, rallies and community events to reinforce the coalition’s message and build trust among constituents.

The coalition is working to counter the BJP’s narratives on governance and development by presenting a clear plan that highlights the ruling party’s shortcomings and persuades voters that it provides a viable alternative.

The coalition is focused on making Ayodhya central to its Assembly election campaign, seeking to use alleged donation irregularities to challenge the BJP’s claim of being the sole defender of Hindu interests.

Social media and digital platforms are also integral to the Opposition’s campaign efforts.

Overall, the Opposition’s preparations indicate a focused attempt to consolidate its efforts, enhance community engagement, and present clear alternatives to the BJP’s policies.

The Opposition has a well-defined strategy and collaboration among various political entities. The INDIA coalition hopes to repeat its 2024 success, but it has cracks.

Since Uttar Pradesh is politically important, it remains to be seen how both sides perform.

PIC TALK



People offer prayers to Lord Jagannath, Balabhadra, and Goddess Subhadra at a temple on the eve of Rath Yatra, in Ahmedabad. PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer
instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Lord Krishna has very emphatically instructed us to treat all souls equally. Aren’t we all parts of God? (The Bhagavad Gita 15.7) Let us see what these instructions are. In the verse #5.7, Lord Krishna states, “A karma Yogi considers souls of other persons similar to his. “Wise persons have equal vision in those who are blessed with knowledge and humility, in a Brahmin and even in an outcast.” (5.18) “One who is equally disposed towards all beings attains the supreme devotion towards Me.” (18.54) The Lord teaches us that external differences like status, etc. are just temporary garments. True wisdom lies in seeing the divine equality — the same eternal essence within everyone, with no exceptions.

Why then we don’t have equal vision towards all souls? Why do we raise some of them to a higher level than us



to the point of taking their shelter, which position is strictly reserved for God? Lord Krishna is very emphatic about taking His shelter, not of anyone else. (18.66) Yes, we can take guidance from a learned person (4.34), help from a highly placed person, etc., but to take shelter of another person is not at all wise.

Let us see what do we lose by taking shelter of anyone other than God. “Worshippers of gods go up to gods, that is they can obtain what gods can give. Worshippers of God go up to Him, that is they can get God’s mercy.” (9.25) In another verse, Lord Krishna states, “Those People, bereft of knowledge, caused by passionate desires, take

shelter of other gods.” (7.20) Just imagine taking shelter of human beings, who are placed lower than gods. This cannot be classed anything like intelligence.

Before I take up benefits of remaining in shelter of God, we must understand more as to why God is so strict about us not taking shelter of another human being. Such a relationship is extremely limited; it can be temporary only. Another is helplessness of all souls without any exceptions, all being small, intrinsically. All depend on God for whatever they need.

Now I come to some benefits of staying in shelter of God. The first one has to be guidance, because direction is all-important, and God is Omniscient. He knows exactly what will suit an individual. And God is there to help where we fall short, which is often, due to us being small, helpless and ignorant too. God does not stop there, if we remain in His shelter; He provides what we need and protects what we have. (9.22) We all have many desires; God fulfils them, the ones according to dharma (highest principles). Once God is in the loop, success is assured in whatever we take up. Forget fears, depression, etc; peace will be ours.

In order to gain all these benefits, we must stop looking for shelter where it is not, neither in human beings nor in material objects like wealth, fame, etc. Just remain in shelter of God now and forever.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

TEACHERS HOLD THE KEY TO FUTURE-READY EDUCATION REFORM

Apropos the opinion piece, “Are Schools Preparing Children for the Future?” by Sakshi Sethi, published on July 15, 2026, the article rightly stresses that education must go beyond marks and memorisation and equip children with critical thinking, financial literacy, public speaking and AI awareness.

However, these reforms require teachers who themselves possess these competencies. Unfortunately, recruitment in most government schools and colleges continues to be largely subject-centric. A teacher may be proficient in a subject but lack the skills to nurture creativity, entrepreneurship, public speaking or problem-solving. Therefore, expecting such skills to flourish in children without preparing their teachers first is

unrealistic.

There is a growing gap in the education system between formal schooling and the skills future generations require, as many parents, apart from paying for schooling, also spend money on private tuition, coding classes and personality development courses.

While the NEP 2020 emphasises experiential and competency-based learning, its implementation also requires continuous teacher training, periodic upskilling, and recruitment policies that value creativity, innovation and practical exposure alongside academic qualifications.

Infrastructure alone cannot transform education. Hence, the quality of the teacher remains the most decisive factor.

SOURAV ASH I KOLKATA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Transparent governance wins trust

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu has, over the years, shown a consistent inclination towards data-backed governance, and his recent initiative to promote data-driven governance for real-time development fits that pattern. Linking AI-based governance tools to grievance redressal is also a sensible step, as technology works best when it is tied to citizen-facing outcomes rather than being used only for internal reporting. The push for zero pendency in the Public Grievance Redressal System, if implemented effectively, could significantly reduce delays faced by ordinary citizens in matters such as land records and other public services.

However, the success of this initiative will depend entirely on how transparently the data is shared. If the Monthly Economic Report remains confined to internal government circles, its purpose will be undermined. It would be beneficial if a simplified public version, with key indicators explained in plain language, were released alongside the official report.

This would enable citizens, researchers and independent economists to assess the State’s progress objectively rather than relying solely on official claims, thereby strengthening transparency, accountability and public trust in governance.

A MYILSAMI I COIMBATURE

Power must not be wasted

Apropos the report on India’s clean energy transition, the country has reached an unexpected milestone. The challenge now is not merely to generate renewable power but to use it efficiently. With solar power reportedly curtailed by around 750 GWh in May 2026, it is evident that inadequate storage capacity and limited grid flexibility are struggling to keep pace with the rapid expansion of renewable energy. Ideally, coal- and gas-fired power plants should reduce output when renewable generation is abundant, thereby conserving fuel and lowering emissions. However, many thermal plants cannot ramp production up and down quickly. Some also operate under contractual minimum-generation obligations, while grid stability still depends on their inertia and dispatchability. Battery Energy Storage Systems, pumped-hydro projects and time-of-day electricity pricing are gathering momentum. Emerging technologies such as sodium-ion batteries, flow batteries and green hydrogen also promise to expand storage options and strengthen energy security.

Simply adding more solar panels is no longer enough. India’s clean energy transition will ultimately be judged not only by how much renewable power it generates, but also by how efficiently every unit is stored, managed and delivered to consumers.

R NARARYAN I NAVI MUMBAI

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Peace ensures maritime safety

The tragic death of an Indian sailor and the injuries sustained by ten others in an Iranian strike have once again highlighted the dangers faced by civilian seafarers operating in volatile regions. This incident is yet another reminder of the need for stronger protection of maritime personnel. The increasing frequency of attacks on commercial vessels also threatens the stability of global trade and supply chains. Therefore, ensuring the safety of merchant ships must remain a shared responsibility of the international community. Diplomatic efforts should focus on preventing conflicts from spilling over into vital maritime routes.

India must continue to engage with affected countries and international maritime organisations to safeguard its citizens working overseas. Shipping companies, too, must enhance security measures, strengthen emergency response systems, and provide comprehensive insurance and welfare support to seafarers and their families.

This tragedy is a reminder that peace at sea is inseparable from peace on land. Greater international cooperation, respect for humanitarian principles, and sustained diplomatic dialogue are essential to prevent such incidents and ensure that innocent seafarers can carry out their duties safely.

RUKHMA SHARMA I JALANDHAR

India can be a trusted textile manufacturer the world is looking for

India’s textile moment has arrived. The world is looking for a trusted manufacturing partner. The question is not whether India can lead, but whether it can execute with the speed and certainty this moment demands



Few countries are better positioned than India to answer this call. Yet India accounts for only about USD 37 billion in textile and apparel exports today-far below its potential. Opportunities of this scale do not emerge often. When they do, countries either build industries around them — or spend decades wondering what might have been.

India possesses a complete textile value chain, deep manufacturing capabilities, a large domestic market and a young workforce. Yet positioning alone does not win markets. Investment does. Execution does. Policy certainty does.

The next decade will not be won by the country that produces the cheapest T-shirt. It will be won by the country that global buyers trust the most.

If India is serious about achieving USD 100 billion in textile and apparel exports by 2030-31 and building a USD 350 billion textile economy, it must prepare for one of the largest investment cycles in the sector's history.

India's textile and apparel market today stands at approximately USD 194 billion, comprising exports of around USD 37 billion and a domestic market of nearly USD 157 billion. Reaching the 2030-31 vision requires the creation of almost USD 156 billion of additional market opportunity within the next five years. This is not incremental growth. It is structural transformation.

Industry assessments suggest that nearly USD 60 billion of fresh investment may be required across the value chain-from fibre and spinning to weaving, processing, garmenting and technical textiles. Beyond exports, this investment can create large-scale employment, strengthen rural economies, deepen manufacturing capabilities and reinforce India's position in global value chains. As one of India's largest employment-generating sectors, textiles can convert manufacturing growth into broad-based economic opportunity.

For decades, textile competitiveness was measured largely through labour costs and production efficiency. Today, the equation has changed. Global buyers increasingly evaluate sourcing destinations through a broader lens: reliability, compliance, sustainability, traceability, resilience and execution capability. The experience of leading exporting nations demonstrates that long-term success is built not only on cost competitiveness, but on buyer confidence. Trust has become a strategic asset.

India's opportunity, therefore, is not simply to become a larger textile producer. It is to become the world's most trusted textile manufacturing partner.

What makes this moment exceptional is not merely the global supply chain shift. It is the convergence of three conditions that rarely align simultaneously.

First, political intent is clear. Initiatives such as PM MITRA, Production Linked Incentive schemes and support for technical textiles demonstrate recognition of textiles as a strategic manufacturing sector.

Second, the administrative machinery is increasingly focused on enabling investment and competitiveness through compliance rationalisation, infrastructure development and ease-of-doing-business reforms.

Third, industry is ready to invest. Across the value chain, companies are evaluating capacity expansion, technology upgradation and sustainability initiatives.

When political leadership, effective governance and industry commitment move in the same direction, nations create industries that endure for generations.

Recent trade agreements and ongoing negotiations are helping address long-standing market-access disadvantages faced by Indian exporters. The India-UK

Global supply chains are being reconfigured at a pace not seen in decades. The world is no longer merely open to alternatives-it is actively searching for them. For the first time in modern textile history, major consumer markets are simultaneously seeking diversification, resilience and trusted manufacturing partners.



CHINA PLUS ONE IS NO LONGER A THEORY; IT IS INCREASINGLY REFLECTED IN SOURCING DECISIONS ACROSS GLOBAL SUPPLY CHAINS. BUYERS ARE ACTIVELY SEEKING RESILIENCE, DIVERSIFICATION AND TRUSTED PARTNERS. THE FUTURE WILL BELONG NOT MERELY TO THE LOWEST-COST PRODUCER, BUT TO THE MOST TRUSTED MANUFACTURING ECOSYSTEM

The writer is Chairman, ASSOCHAM National Council on Textiles and Technical Textiles

FTA, progress in negotiations with the European Union and agreements with key trading partners are steadily improving India's competitive position in global markets. However, market access alone is not enough. Preferential tariffs without competitive supply remain an unrealised opportunity. Trade agreements create openings. Competitiveness converts them into exports.

Raw material competitiveness remains critical. Manufacturers making decade-long investment decisions need confidence that internationally competitive fibre and raw materials will remain available throughout the life of those investments. Similarly, export remission frameworks such as RoSCTL and RoDTEP require continuity, predictability and appropriate upward revision to keep pace with rising domestic costs and unrebrated taxes. These mechanisms are not incentives; they are essential competitiveness tools that neutralise embedded taxes and levies and help maintain a level playing field for Indian exporters. Policy certainty is often the difference between investment announced and investment implemented.

India must also accelerate the development of a textile machinery manufacturing ecosystem. The country continues to import significant volumes of advanced machinery every year. India should not aspire only to manufacture textiles. It should aspire to manufacture the machinery that manufactures textiles. Targeted foreign direct investment, technology partnerships and phased localisation can build capabilities not only in textile production but in textile technology itself. Manufacturing competitiveness ultimately rests on technological competitiveness.

Technical textiles represent one of India's most promising growth frontiers. From medical textiles and geotextiles to filtration fabrics, defence applications and advanced industrial solutions, this segment combines strategic relevance with high-value manufacturing potential. It offers India an opportunity not merely to participate in global markets, but to build leadership positions in emerging applications where demand is expected to grow rapidly in the years ahead.

China Plus One is no longer a theory; it is increasingly reflected in sourcing decisions across global supply chains. Buyers are actively seeking resilience, diversification and trusted partners. The future will belong not merely to the lowest-cost producer, but to the most trusted manufacturing ecosystem.

India possesses the raw materials, entrepreneurial talent, manufacturing depth, domestic demand and demographic advantage required to emerge as a global textile powerhouse. The question is no longer whether India can achieve USD 100 billion in textile and apparel exports. The question is whether we are willing to make the investments, undertake the reforms and create the policy certainty required to get there.

India's textile moment has arrived. The world is looking for a trusted manufacturing partner. The question is not whether India can lead, but whether it can execute with the speed and certainty this moment demands.

Ram temple: India’s civilisational awakening



VK BAHUGUNA

Baba Fakir Singh Khalsa, entered the complex and built a clay platform (Chabutara) inside the premises, placed a picture or symbol of Lord Ram and wrote “Ram Ram” in charcoal on the walls. They performed a Vedic havan and left. An FIR was later registered against them on November 30, 1858 by the mosque muezzin. This action by the Nihangs is a crucial document proving that Hindus had been worshipping here for a long time. Then again, in the night of December 22-23, 1949, a group led by Mahant Abhiram Das entered the locked Babri mosque and placed a nine-inch metal idol of Ram Lala beneath the central dome.

A large gathering of thousands thronged the site, and to prevent communal escalation the administration locked the outer gates but allowed a Hindu priest inside to perform limited daily puja and bhoj offerings to the idol. The then Prime Minister Nehru directed that the idol be removed, but the District Magistrate KK Nayar took a pragmatic decision to avoid communal tension by sealing the main building and allowing a lone priest to perform basic puja only; this continued until February 1986, when the locks were opened under a court order officially granting Hindus access to the inner section for worship. The rest is history until January 22, 2024, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the majestic temple constructed after the November 9, 2019 Supreme Court verdict.

Why write this article now, when the Ram Temple is in the news for the wrong reasons? The immediate cause is the public uproar regarding theft of donations and an alleged financial scam in which staff responsible for its safekeeping were siphoning off crores. Some quick action has been taken and things are on the right path, but baying for the blood of the people at the helm who trusted these thieves — due to lack of administrative acumen — and smearing the entire temple management is undesirable and suggests ulterior motives. Such things can happen in any religious institution.

For example, a massive Vatican financial scandal involving Cardinal Becciu began in 2019; he was stripped of his rights as a cardinal and, after trial, was convicted in December 2020. Similarly, the Caritas Luxembourg 61.2 million bank and donation fraud case began in 2014 and continued until 2026. In October 2024 former congregants filed a major financial fraud lawsuit against Gateway Church of Texas. These accusations were often directed at top management, whereas the Ram temple case appears to involve petty thieves and not the trustees. It is therefore highly undesirable to accuse senior management without evidence.

Likewise, in Islam the misuse and diversion of zakat — which is analogous to donations - has been a persistent issue. Investigations into the Bashir regime in Sudan revealed that funds intended for the poor were routinely diverted to entities linked to the regime. Similar inquiries have been reported against various charities in the Middle East. These incidents, including Ayodhya, underscore the global challenge of maintaining transparency and the need for continuous oversight over massive flows of donations and gifts, and they call for strict internal audit and modern accounting and management procedures.

It seems many people want to take advantage of this event politically, particularly those who opposed the Ram temple's construction and who pander to vote bank appeasement politics. In reality, portraying the issue as an attack on the Hindu religion — ostensibly at the behest of “woke” Western elites with double standards — misreads the situation. The global progressive movement vocally supports land-back movements, the return of sacred sites to Native Americans, and the decolonisation of African and Australian spaces. Yet when the same logic of decolonisation and the restoration of sacred indigenous geography was applied to Ayodhya — backed by an exhaustive, multi-decade legal process and conclusive archaeological evidence from the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) - it was branded regressive by some of their Indian cohorts.

Thus, in global media, academic circles and certain domestic intellectual hubs, the event leading to the Ram temple's construction was frequently framed not as a moment of cultural healing but through the modern lens of hyper-nationalism and as an instance of majoritarianism. This globalised “woke” framework inherently struggles to accommodate non-Western civilisational icons. The Anglo American woke club views the world from an exclusive Western template. Christianity and whiteness are historically associated with institutional power and colonial expansion. But when it comes to India, any attempt to promote cultural renaissance is instantly mapped to Western imperialism, dismissively ignoring Hinduism's history as a victim of brutal, multi century colonial and imperial onslaughts, and viewing the assertiveness of Hinduism with suspicion.

Therefore, when Hindus pointed to archaeological and historical evidence of a temple being demolished to build a mosque, the narrative was systematically suppressed or downplayed by Marxist and progressive historians for decades. Lord Ram is not only a deity but an icon of righteousness and the soul of the foundations of Indian civilisation's core elements of governance. Unlike many ancient pagan or indigenous civilisations that were entirely erased by global colonial movements, India's indigenous civilisation survived. The reclamation of Ayodhya is a manifestation of that survival.

For global critical theorists, an indigenous majority asserting its historic rights and building a monument to its survival disrupts the standard post colonial narrative, which often prefers indigenous cultures to remain permanently oppressed. Thus the controversy surrounding the Ram Mandir is a clash between a globalised intellectual elite and an assertive India. The “woke” view sees the Ram Mandir as a fracture in secularism, whereas the vast majority of India views it as the healing of a historical wound. India is asserting its right to define its own modernity, its own secularism, and its own path towards justice.



The writer is a former IFS officer and Chairman of the Centre for Resource Management and Environment

The U-turn we all need: Rediscovering the life we forgot to live



PRATIKSHA VATS

For many, this question arrives late — after years of chasing promotions, possessions, recognition, and approval. We spend our youth building a future, but sometimes forget to ask whether that future will truly make us happy.

The modern world has created an unusual paradox. We have more comfort, technology, and opportunities than previous generations, yet many people experience increasing stress, loneliness, and dissatisfaction. We are connected to everyone, but often disconnected from ourselves.

Perhaps the problem is not that we are moving too slowly. Perhaps the problem is that we are moving without checking the direction.

A meaningful life is not created by constantly adding more achievements. It is created by understanding what truly deserves our time, energy, and attention.

The cost of always moving forward

From childhood, we are trained to move ahead —

score better, earn more, achieve bigger goals. Ambition is valuable, but ambition without awareness can become a never-ending race.

Many people reach milestones they once dreamed about and still feel something is missing. The reason is simple: success achieved without personal meaning can feel surprisingly empty.

Modern studies on human well-being often emphasise that happiness is not determined only by external achievements. Our health, relationships, sense of purpose, and ability to make authentic choices play a much deeper role in creating a satisfying life.

The real question is not only: “How much have I achieved?” It is also: “What has my achievement turned me into?”

Health: The first responsibility we neglect

One of life's greatest ironies is that people often sacrifice their health while trying to build a better future, only to spend that future trying to regain their health.

Sleep is reduced, stress becomes normal, and the body is treated as if it has unlimited capacity. But the human body keeps a record of everything we ignore.

Health is not merely the absence of illness. It is the ability to wake up with energy, think clearly, and experience life fully.

A balanced life does not always demand dramatic changes or complete transformation. Often, the most meaningful improvements come from



simple and consistent choices — respecting the body's need for proper sleep, eating with awareness, staying physically active, and creating moments of silence away from the constant noise of modern life.

These small habits may appear ordinary, but over time they shape our energy, emotions, and overall quality of life. A peaceful mind is not a luxury reserved for those who have achieved success; it is the foundation that allows success to have real meaning.

Relationships: The people behind our purpose

At the end of our journey, we rarely remember only our achievements. We remember conversations, laughter, support, and the people who stood beside us.

Research on human happiness has consistently shown that meaningful relationships are among

the strongest contributors to long-term well-being. Yet modern life often creates a strange situation — we have countless online connections but fewer moments of genuine connection.

A relationship cannot survive on occasional messages and digital reactions. It needs presence.

Sometimes the most valuable thing we can give another person is not advice or solutions, but our undivided attention. A successful life becomes meaningful only when there are people with whom it can be shared.

Work: Achievement with purpose

Work occupies a significant part of our lives, but its purpose should extend beyond simply earning a living. True fulfilment comes when our efforts create value — not only for ourselves but also for the world around us.

Instead of measuring success only through income, positions, or recognition, we must ask deeper questions: Are we learning? Are we growing? Are we creating something meaningful? A person who finds purpose in their work does not avoid challenges; rather, they accept difficulties because they understand the reason behind them.

The aim is not to escape responsibility, but to ensure that our responsibilities are connected to a larger purpose, allowing our work to become a source of growth, contribution, and personal satisfaction.

The courage to choose your own path

Perhaps the hardest part of life is not working hard

— it is being honest about what we are working toward.

Society often provides ready-made definitions of success. It tells us what careers to admire, what lifestyles to follow, and what achievements to chase.

But a life designed only around expectations can become a life lived by someone else's rules.

Choosing your own path requires courage because it may not always receive immediate approval. Saying “no” to certain expectations may feel uncomfortable, but sometimes it is necessary to protect your peace.

You cannot build a meaningful life by constantly trying to satisfy everyone else.

The real meaning of a U-turn

A U-turn is usually seen as a mistake on the road. But in life, it can be a sign of maturity.

Changing direction does not mean losing everything you have built. Sometimes it means using your experience to choose better.

The wisest people are not those who never change their path. They are those who recognise when their current path no longer matches their values. Life is not a race where the fastest person wins. It is a journey where direction matters more than speed. A U-turn in life is not about starting over; it is about having the awareness to pause, the courage to change direction, and the wisdom to move toward a life that truly belongs to us.

The writer is a Nutritionist, Wellness Coach and Health Writer

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

Delhi HC to hear PIL over Sonam Wangchuk's deteriorating health



The Delhi High Court said it will hear on Thursday a public interest litigation raising concern over the health of activist Sonam Wangchuk, who is on an indefinite fast at Jantar Mantar here. The Cockroach Janta Party has been holding the protest for over 25 days demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination. Wangchuk joined the agitation on June 28 and has been on an indefinite fast since then. A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia on Wednesday deferred hearing on the PIL after noting that none appeared for the authorities amid the ongoing work abstention called by the high court's bar association.

"Having regard to urgency, list tomorrow," the bench said. The court ordered that a copy of the order be served to the Additional Solicitor General concerned and the Delhi government counsel. Petitioner Rakesh Kumar Saini said the situation was "sad" and "most unfortunate" as a protesting citizen was "virtually taking his life in front of the whole nation." In his PIL, Saini sought direction to the authorities to come to Wangchuk's aid and "discuss the issue" with him.

SC grants bail to man involved in district mineral fund 'scam'



The Supreme Court on Wednesday granted bail to an alleged kingpin in a corruption case involving "irregularities" in the District Mineral Fund (DMF) in Chhattisgarh.

The DMF scam is a financial embezzlement case and revolves around the corruption and diversion of funds meant for the welfare of local mining-affected communities.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of senior advocate Shoenb Alam, appearing for accused Satpal Singh Chhabra, that many co-accused, including retired Chhattisgarh-cadre IAS officer Anil Tuteja have been granted bail in the case.

"Main accused Anil Tuteja was granted bail on May 18, 2026," the bench said and granted bail to Chhabra.

The bench said the accused will have to submit bail to the satisfaction of the trial court which may also impose other conditions. Chhabra, the alleged kingpin, is accused of receiving '5 crore as illegal gratification in the award of contracts under the DMF. Earlier, the bench had granted bail to Tuteja after taking note of the fact that the former bureaucrat was in jail since January 24, 2024 in various corruption cases. Tuteja was arrested in the DMF case on February 23, 2026.

Delhi court restores Umar Khalid's two weekly e-mulakats with family

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has allowed jailed activist Umar Khalid to have two video meetings (e-mulakats) with his family every week after his counsel claimed it was reduced to one from May 2026 without any reason.

Additional Sessions Judge Sameer Bajpai noted that he had been availing the facility for the past six years without violating prison rules.

The court passed the order on an application moved by Khalid, who has been facing trial in the larger conspiracy case related to the 2020 northeast Delhi riots.

In the order dated July 13, the court said, "Since the applicant has been using two e-mulakats in a week for the



last six years and has not violated any rule of the Delhi Prisons Rules, the applicant is allowed to have two e-mulakats per week for the purpose of talking to his mother and other family members". Khalid's counsel submit-



TMC's Abhishek gives voice sample to magistrate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee on Wednesday provided his voice sample to a magistrate at the Bidhannagar SDJM court near here in connection with an investigation into his alleged intimidatory speech during the West Bengal assembly election campaign.

The Calcutta High Court had, on July 10, directed Banerjee to appear before the magistrate at noon on July 15 for the purpose.

Banerjee was at the court for nearly one-and-a-half hours for providing the voice sample to the magistrate, for which an expert was present.

He did not respond to queries from journalists



TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee being escorted by police and security personnel as he leaves after giving his voice sample before a magistrate in connection with an investigation into his alleged intimidatory speech during the West Bengal assembly election campaign, at the Bidhannagar court, in Kolkata

present at the venue and left the court premises soon after the process concluded. The TMC MP had not

appeared before the magistrate on two earlier dates, ordered by the Bidhannagar court, for giving his voice

sample on a prayer by the investigating agency. A huge posse of police personnel was deployed in

Criticism of govt, CM not 'war' against nation: Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

A Pune court has granted bail to an NCP (SP) office-bearer, stating that criticism of the government or the chief minister, by itself, cannot be construed as "waging war" against the nation.

Every citizen has the right to comment on, compliment and criticise the government's actions, Additional Sessions Judge B D Kulkarni said on Tuesday while allowing NCP (SP) functionary Mahadev Balgude's bail plea.

Balgude, the state head of the social media wing of Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP), was arrested in April this



year on charges of circulating morphed photos of Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on social media platforms and also

posting content allegedly sympathetic to Naxalites.

Among other sections, Balgude was booked under Section 152 of the Bharatiya

Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which deals with purposely or knowingly endangering the sovereignty, unity, and integrity of India.

The court noted that the case papers showed the applicant had questioned the investigation process in certain cases and the functioning of government schemes, which fell within the realm of public discourse.

"Nothing on record suggests that the accused has declared or incited waging war against the State or committed any act endangering the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India," it observed.

HC cancels bail to female teacher in Janakpuri school rape case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday cancelled the bail granted to a female teacher in a case concerning the alleged rape of a three-year-old girl by a staff member inside a private school in west Delhi's Janakpuri area, and asked her to surrender in three days.

On June 29, the high court had also set aside the bail granted to the main accused, the caretaker of the school, and asked him to surrender on July 1.

Justice Saurabh Banerjee on Wednesday allowed the Delhi Police's plea challenging the trial court order that granted bail to the teacher on May 20 in the case registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual



Offences (POCSO) Act. "The respondent is directed to surrender in three days," Justice Banerjee said.

The teacher was arrested for

allegedly concealing the incident from authorities and was remanded in one-day police custody by the trial court on May 14.

The incident came to light on May 1 when the girl's mother filed a complaint at Janakpuri police station, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours by the caretaker.

According to the complaint, the child had gone to the school on April 30, the second day after her admission. After returning home, she complained of pain. When questioned by her mother, the girl said that she was taken to an isolated area in the school, where the man allegedly assaulted her.

SC gives Odisha govt deadline to consider Dara Singh's remission plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has given the Odisha government a month to decide on the remission plea of a "repenting" Ravindra Pal, alias Dara Singh, who is serving life sentence for the murders of Australian missionary Graham Stuart Staines and his two minor sons in Keonjhar district in 1999.

A bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi posted the matter for hearing on August 19 after the state government sought time.

"Let him also celebrate Independence Day. You must

take a decision by August 15," the court told the counsel for the Odisha government on Tuesday.

The bench had earlier as well asked the state's sentence review committee to take a call on Singh's remission plea.

"A request has been made on behalf of the state that the matter may be adjourned for a short period as the committee which was to take a decision has called for the records and those records are yet to be made available to them," it said while posting the matter for further hearing.

"In the meantime, we expect that the committee



shall take its decision," it added.

A mob led by Singh attacked Staines and his two sons — 11-year-old Philip and eight-year-old Timothy — while they slept in their

station wagon and set the vehicle on fire in Manoharpur village of Keonjhar district on the intervening night of January 22-23, 1999.

Singh, the main accused in the triple murder, was con-

and around the Bidhannagar court premises in Salt Lake to ensure that no untoward incident occurs during Banerjee's appearance.

On a plea by his lawyer, the high court directed the police authorities to ensure that the Diamond Harbour MP is not subjected to hurling of eggs or any other harassment when he appears before the jurisdictional court or the investigating agency.

Banerjee was heckled when he visited a deceased party supporter's house at Sonarpur on May 30.

The high court had on July 10 expressed displeasure at the TMC MP for "not cooperating" with the investigation into the alleged intimidatory speech he made during the West Bengal assembly polls, held on April 29.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya had "dismissed as withdrawn" a criminal revisional application of Banerjee challenging the Bidhanagar court's direction for him to give his voice sample in connection with the probe.

The high court directed Banerjee to comply with its May 21 order that granted protection from coercive action till July 31 in the intimidatory speech case, contingent on his cooperation with the investigation.

The TMC MP has petitioned the high court to quash the FIR regarding his alleged intimidatory comments against a rival party's leaders and workers at a public meeting before the second phase of the West Bengal assembly polls, held on April 29.



Draft final probe report in Ahmedabad plane crash to be ready in October: AAIB to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has told the Supreme Court that draft final report of the probe into the June 2025 Air India flight AI-171 crash in Ahmedabad, which killed 260 people, is expected to be ready in October this year.

In a detailed affidavit filed before the top court, the AAIB said there is an "absolute statutory prohibition" on disclosing cockpit voice recordings and airborne image recordings from the June 12, 2025, Ahmedabad plane crash to any external committee or the public.

The AAIB said that sharing such material would violate Rule 17(1) and Rule 17(5) read with Schedule C of the Aircraft (Investigation of Accidents and Incidents) Rules, 2025.

It submitted that a serious

accident involving an international flight is not a matter purely of domestic inquiry, but one of international inquiry governed by the Chicago Convention and Annex 13 of the International Civil Aviation Organisation's rules.

Annex 13 prescribes the standard operating procedure to conduct an aircraft accident investigation.

"Article 26 obligates the State in which the accident occurs to institute an inquiry into the circumstances of the accident, while Annex 13 read with Aircraft (Investigation of Accidents and Incidents) Rules, 2025, expressly contemplates the participation of the State of Registry, State of Operator, State of Design, and State of Manufacture, each of whom possesses defined rights and responsibilities in the investigative process through accredited representatives and technical participation.

Two Bangladeshi women get two-year imprisonment for illegal stay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court has sentenced two Bangladeshi women to two years' imprisonment for illegally entering India and residing here without valid documentation.

Additional Sessions Judge VG Mohite passed the order on Tuesday after the two accused, identified as Shahna Bilal Saddar (43) and Hasina Jabbar Khan (45), pleaded guilty to the charges against them.



Pleading for leniency, the defence counsel argued that both women were from impoverished backgrounds, married, had no prior criminal record, and were the sole breadwinners for their respective families.

Accepting the plea, the court convicted both individuals for violations under the Foreigners Act and the Passport Act. As the women had been incarcerated since their arrest on December 3, 2024, they were granted a set-off for the detention period already undergone.

SC to hear ED plea against transfer of Amrapali money laundering case to Ghaziabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to hear the plea of Enforcement Directorate against the Allahabad High Court order transferring a money laundering case related to siphoning off homebuyers' money by the Amrapali group.

The Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court on August 11, 2025, had ordered the transfer of a money laundering case filed by the ED against Ajay Kumar and two others from a special PMLA court in Lucknow to a designated court in Ghaziabad.

A Supreme Court bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the



submissions of Additional Solicitor General S V Raju that the high court wrongly transferred the money laundering case.

The bench also issued notices to former promoters of the real estate firm, Anil Kumar Sharma, Ajay Kumar, and Shiv Priya.

The high court had allowed the application and held that the transfer was warranted in view of the Central government's notification dated October 7, 2022, issued under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

The accused had contend-

ed that since the alleged offence pertains to Gautam Buddha Nagar district in Uttar Pradesh, the case should be tried by the Special Court, Anti-Corruption, CBI (West), Ghaziabad, as specified in the 2022 notification. The ED had opposed the plea, relying on the Supreme Court's decision.

However, the high court rejected the ED's contention, observing that the arguments advanced by the agency were not in consonance with the statutory notification governing the territorial jurisdiction of designated PMLA courts.

Allowing the application, the high court directed that the pending complaint case before the Special PMLA Court in Lucknow be transferred to the designated Special Court at Ghaziabad.

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

Urea policy to boost fertiliser, energy security: GTRC-India

The National Investment Policy for Urea 2026, approved by the Cabinet on Wednesday, will provide long-term policy certainty and strengthen the country's fertiliser and energy security, Gasification Technologies & Research Council of India (GTRC-India) said. The policy will encourage new investments in the urea sector to set up gas-based urea manufacturing units in the country.

GTRC-India said the policy mainly targets natural gas-based projects but also opens a pathway to gradually integrate coal gasification into the urea sector. By introducing a transparent cost framework, assured returns of 12-16 per cent, and protection against foreign exchange volatility, the policy creates a robust investment environment for new urea capacity.

"With domestic demand growing at nearly five per cent annually, over 27 per cent import dependence, and 82 per cent of existing plants more than 25 years old, timely capacity addition has become imperative," GTRC-India President Balasaheb Darade said.

Leveraging domestic coal can cut dependence on imported LNG and improve long-term subsidy efficiency. While the policy currently focuses on natural gas-based projects, it also presents a strategic opportunity to progressively integrate coal gasification into India's fertiliser ecosystem.

The policy aims to create fresh domestic urea capacity of 10 million tonnes and make India self-reliant in the most widely consumed fertiliser in the country. GTRC-India is a national industry platform set up to advance the gasification ecosystem through collaboration, knowledge sharing, technology development, research partnerships and strategic engagement.

It represents stakeholders across India's expanding coal gasification, coal-to-chemicals and downstream manufacturing sectors. (PTI)

Gold futures slip to ₹1,41,274/10g

Gold prices on Wednesday dropped by ₹983 to ₹1,41,274 per 10 grams in futures trade amid uncertainties in West Asia.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, yellow metal contracts for August delivery traded lower by ₹983, or 0.69 per cent, at ₹1,41,274 per 10 grams in a business turnover of 1,289 lots.

"Gold prices dropped in the domestic markets on Wednesday as geopolitical tensions surrounding the Iran conflict intensified, affecting investor sentiment," said Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk. Globally, gold futures declined by 0.55 per cent to \$4,030.36 per ounce in New York. (PTI)

India gets duty-free access for over 11 lakh tonnes of steel exports to UK under trade pact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian exporters will be able to ship over 11 lakh tonnes of steel annually to the UK duty-free under the free trade agreement, which came into force on Wednesday, through a combination of country-specific and residual quotas, an official said.

The UK's March steel safeguard measures had become a major sticking point in implementing the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), which was signed on July 24, 2025. The resolution of the issue has paved the way for the implementation of the agreement from July 15.

Overall, 188 steel items accounting for \$137 million worth of steel exports from India to Britain were covered by these safeguard measures. India's total steel exports were \$960 million in 2025.

To protect the interest of our exporters, India engaged

extensively with the UK side to mitigate the impact of the steel measure on India's exporters.

Based on the consultations with stakeholders, India requested the UK for enhancing quota for India under the steel measure.

After prolonged and intense discussions at all levels between the two sides, India has been able to secure robust market access and continuity for Indian exporters, the Government official said. "As a result of these successful negotiations, India's total country-specific

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | JULY 16, 2026

India's refining rise: From oil importer to global fuel supplier

RUPAK CHATTOPADHYAY

India's transformation into a major refining power represents one of the most significant developments in the global downstream energy landscape over the past three decades. For decades, the country's energy story was defined by dependence: a rapidly growing economy with limited domestic crude production and heavy reliance on imports. Today, that narrative is changing. India is emerging as one of the world's most important processors and exporters of refined petroleum products.

Just three decades ago, India's refining sector was largely inward-looking, focused primarily on meeting domestic shortages rather than competing in global markets. The transformation began with economic liberalisation in the 1990s and accelerated with the development of large, export-oriented refineries such as the Jamnagar complex. Since then, India has evolved from a country that was periodically dependent on imported refined fuels to supplement domestic supply into one of the world's largest exporters of petroleum products, supplying markets across Asia, Africa, Europe, and the Middle East.

The scale of this transformation is considerable. India currently has approximately 258 million tonnes per annum (MMTPA) of refining capacity, equivalent to around 5.2 million barrels per day (bpd). This makes India the world's third-largest refining hub after the United States and China. Government and industry plans envisage expanding refining capacity to approximately 300 MMTPA by the end of the decade, although several major projects remain subject to investment decisions, financing, and imple-

mentation timelines. Even with these uncertainties, India's refining footprint is expected to continue expanding, strengthening its position in global fuel markets.

The importance of India's refining sector is not measured only by domestic consumption. It is increasingly reflected in its export performance. According to data from the Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell (PPAC), India exported approximately 64.7 million tonnes of petroleum products in FY2024-25, equivalent to more than one million barrels per day. The country ships gasoline, diesel, aviation turbine fuel, fuel oil, and petrochemical feedstocks to markets across Asia, Africa, Europe, and the Middle East. Maritime intelligence firm Kpler reported that India's fuel exports reached a record 1.28 million bpd in 2025.

The significance of India's refining sector becomes even clearer when exports are measured relative to total production rather than simply to installed capacity. Indian refineries typically operate at utilisation rates of around 100-105 per cent of nameplate capacity through operational optimisation, producing approximately 250-270 million tonnes of petroleum products annually. Of this output, roughly one-quarter — around 64-65 million tonnes — is exported. This makes India one of the world's most export-oriented major refining centres.

This export orientation gives India a distinctive position in global energy markets. The United States exports larger absolute volumes of refined products, but its enormous domestic market absorbs much of its refining output. China has built one of the world's largest refining systems, but refined product exports are managed through State-controlled quota mechanisms and are closely linked to domestic industrial policy. India occupies a different position: it combines a massive and rapidly growing domestic market with a refining sector capable of

consistently supplying international consumers.

India's competitiveness has also been strengthened by changes in global crude markets. Following Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Indian refiners substantially increased purchases of discounted Russian crude. While operating within prevailing international sanctions frameworks governing maritime trade and price restrictions, Indian refiners benefited from access to lower-cost feedstock, improving refinery margins and enhancing the competitiveness of exported petroleum products. This helped India expand its role as a supplier of diesel, gasoline, aviation fuel, and other products during a period of significant disruption in global energy markets.

India's export capability changes its role in the global energy system. Unlike traditional oil powers that derive influence from controlling crude reserves, India's influence increasingly comes from its ability to transform crude sourced from multiple countries into products required by global consumers. Indian refiners can process crude from the Middle East, Russia, Africa, and the Americas, allowing them to optimise procurement according to price, quality, and market conditions.

A key source of India's competitive advantage is not only scale but also technological sophistication. Many Indian refineries rank among the most complex in the world, with high refining complexity that allows them

to process a wide range of crude grades, including heavier and more challenging feedstocks. This flexibility enables refiners to maximise production of higher-value products such as transportation fuels, petrochemical feedstocks, and specialty products. In a volatile global oil market, the ability to adapt crude inputs and optimise output has become a major strategic advantage.

This creates a distinct competitive position. The United States remains the world's largest refining power, supported by abundant domestic crude production, extensive pipeline networks, and deeply integrated energy infrastructure. China has built one of the world's largest refining systems through sustained state-backed investment in refining and petrochemicals. Gulf producers, including Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, are also moving further downstream, investing in large export-oriented refineries to capture more value from their hydrocarbon resources.

India's model is different. The country has emerged as a global-scale refining power without being a major crude producer while simultaneously developing one of the world's most export-oriented downstream sectors. Its competitive advantage lies in the combination of a vast domestic market, strategic geography, sophisticated refining capabilities, high operational utilisation, modern port infrastructure, and the ability to connect suppliers and con-

sumers across multiple regions.

The Jamnagar refining complex operated by Reliance Industries exemplifies this transformation. With a refining capacity of approximately 1.24 million barrels per day, it is the world's largest refining complex and has played a central role in establishing India as a major exporter of transportation fuels and petrochemical products.

It is also significant that successive US administrations have generally accepted India's expanding role as a supplier of refined petroleum products to global markets, including Europe, even as India increased purchases of Russian crude after 2022. Under prevailing sanctions frameworks, refined products processed in India continued to reach international markets, providing European consumers with an additional source of fuel supplies at a time when energy security had become a central concern. For the United States, India's emergence as a major refining hub has broadly aligned with wider strategic objectives by increasing flexibility in global energy markets and reinforcing India's role as a key partner in the Indo-Pacific.

The episode underscores a broader shift in global energy power. Influence is no longer determined solely by control over crude oil reserves; it increasingly rests with countries that possess the infrastructure and capability to process, store, and redistribute energy at scale.

The India-UAE crude storage partnership further demonstrates how major producers increasingly view India not only as a consumer market but also as a strategic energy platform. By placing crude inventories in India, producers gain closer access to Asian demand centres, while India gains greater supply flexibility, improved energy security, and deeper strategic relationships with major producers.

The combination of refining

capacity, strategic petroleum storage, ports, and export infrastructure creates a new form of energy influence. This strategic value becomes even clearer during periods of geopolitical disruption, particularly around the Strait of Hormuz. Any disruption to Gulf shipping routes would affect not only crude availability but also refined product flows across Asia. Countries with flexible refining systems, diversified crude sourcing, and sophisticated logistics networks are better positioned to manage volatility.

India's expanding refining footprint provides precisely that flexibility. The country can diversify crude sourcing, adjust refinery operations, and continue supplying both domestic and international markets. Its role as a major exporter of refined products gives India influence well beyond its own borders, particularly among energy-importing economies across South Asia, Africa, and the wider Indo-Pacific.

This represents a fundamental shift in India's global energy position. The country is moving from being a vulnerable buyer of crude to becoming an increasingly important participant in the global energy value chain. Producers are seeking deeper access to India's market, while consumers are increasingly relying on India's refining capacity.

The future of energy influence will not be determined solely by who controls the largest oil reserves. It will also be shaped by who controls the infrastructure that transforms raw resources into the fuels, chemicals, and products that modern economies require. India has spent three decades building that infrastructure — and continues to expand it. In doing so, it is emerging not simply as one of the world's largest oil consumers, but as one of the world's most consequential refining and fuel-exporting powers.

Rupak Chattopadhyay has served as President and CEO of the Forum of Federations since 2011

Stock markets recover on buying in bank stocks, Sensex rises by 130 pts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty recovered on Wednesday following buying in bank stocks and softer-than-expected US inflation data, reinforcing expectations that the Federal Reserve may adopt a less aggressive monetary policy stance in the coming months.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 130.49 points, or 0.17 per cent, to settle at 77,185.43. During the day, it jumped 591.33 points, or 0.76 per cent, to 77,646.27.

The 50-share NSE Nifty went up 26.45 points, or 0.11 per cent, to end at 24,078.50.

Escalating hostilities between the US and Iran, however, kept investors'

The figure consists of two charts. The left chart is a line graph titled 'BSE SENSEX' showing the index's movement from June 2026 to July. It starts at 74,267.34 and ends at 77,185.43, with a daily gain of 130.49 points. The right chart is an 'Intra-day on July 15' candlestick chart showing price fluctuations from 9 am to 4 pm. It shows a high of 77,800 and a low of 76,800, with a closing price of 77,185.43. A table on the right lists top gainers and losers.

Top Gainers	%	Top Losers	%
ETERNAL	3.08	Power Grid	-1.73
Ultra Tech	2.77	L&T	-1.69
SBI	1.50	Tata Steel	-1.65
Bajaj Finance	1.49	Infosys	-1.41
IndiGO	1.09	NTPC	-1.12

sentiment subdued in the second half of the trade, triggering profit-taking.

From the Sensex pack, Eternal, UltraTech Cement, State Bank of India, Bajaj Finance, InterGlobe Aviation, and Asian Paints were among the major winners.

Power Grid, Larsen & Toubro, Tata Steel, and Infosys were among the laggards.

In Asian markets, South Korea's Kospi jumped 6.24 per cent. Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index also ended higher, while Shanghai's SSE Composite index settled lower. Markets in Europe were quoted lower. US markets ended higher on Tuesday.

"Domestic equities exhibited resilience, with broader

markets outperforming large caps amid positive Asian cues," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

Softer US inflation data supported sentiment, he added.

Broader markets advanced, with the BSE MidCap Select index climbing 0.59 per cent and SmallCap Select index going up by 0.42 per cent.

Crude oil futures rally as US-Iran conflict deepens

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Crude oil futures extended gains for the third straight session on Wednesday, rising ₹105 to ₹7,689 per barrel, as traders priced in mounting supply risks following another round of US strikes on Iran.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude oil futures for July delivery rose ₹105, or 1.38 per cent, to

₹7,689 per barrel in a business turnover of 10,458 lots. The August contract also went up by ₹91, or 1.12 per cent, to ₹7,665 per barrel in 8,798 lots on the MCX.

Traders said mounting geopolitical tensions in West Asia drove the latest gains after the US intensified its military operations against Iran, raising concerns over crude shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial artery for global oil trade.

Rupee declines 16 paise to settle at 96.32 against USD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee fell 16 paise to close at 96.32 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by heightened tensions in West Asia and a rise in global crude oil prices.

However, positive sentiments in the domestic equity markets and a weaker greenback prevented a sharper decline in the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.12 and traded in the range of 96.04-96.32 during the session. It settled at 96.32 (provisional), down 16 paise from its previous close.

The rupee depreciated 48 paise to close at 96.16 against the US dollar on Tuesday. The US military reimposed a naval blockade on Iran and intensified its airstrike campaign early on Wednesday, hitting an Iranian army barracks and

The figure is a line chart titled 'Rupee vs Dollar' showing the exchange rate of ₹ per US \$ from July 8 to July 15, 2026. The rate starts at 95.47 and ends at 96.32, with a daily decline of 16 paise. A table on the right lists the daily rates.

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)
8	95.47
9	95.48
10	95.38
11	95.38
12	95.68
13	95.68
14	96.16
15	96.32

killing at least seven troops while wounding 260 people across the country. Days of retaliatory strikes across West Asia by Iran and the US, and both nations' attempts to assert control over the Strait of Hormuz, threaten to push the region back to an all-out war.

Meanwhile, The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 100.78, down 0.14 per cent.

Kia Syros EV bookings open in India at ₹25,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Kia India has unveiled the Syros EV, its second mass-market electric SUV for India, and opened pre-bookings at ₹25,000. Positioned as a confidence-building EV for mainstream buyers, the Syros EV brings a claimed ARAI-certified range of 526 km with the larger 51.4 kWh battery pack, making it the first in its segment to cross the 500 km mark. A 42 kWh version is also on offer with a claimed range of 443 km.

The new SUV is aimed at addressing the three biggest concerns around EV ownership: range, resale value and battery life. Kia is backing the Syros EV with a lifetime high-voltage battery warranty, an assured buyback programme and Battery-as-a-Service financing to reduce upfront costs. The company says the package is designed to make electric mobility more predictable and worry-free for Indian customers.

On the performance front, the Syros EV develops 171 PS, which Kia says is best-in-segment, and can accelerate from 0 to 100 kmph in 8.1 seconds with the larger battery. Fast charging from 10 to 80 per cent takes 39 minutes using a 100 kW DC charger. The SUV also gets a battery conditioning function to improve charging efficiency, along with 10.8 kW AC charging support.

Kia has equipped the Syros EV with a long list of connected and convenience features. These include its K-Charge ecosystem,

which brings more than 20,300 charging points across 23 operators into a single wallet on the MyKia app. The vehicle also gets a 30-inch panoramic display panel, Harman Kardon eight-speaker audio, OTA updates, wireless smartphone connectivity, ventilated seats, a dual-pane sunroof and a 16-litre frunk.

Safety is another major focus. The Syros EV comes with Level 2 ADAS featuring 16 autonomous functions, including adaptive cruise control, lane-keeping assist and forward collision-avoidance features. It also gets six airbags, ESC, hill-start assist, a tyre pressure monitoring system and a 360-degree camera.

Kia will offer the Syros EV in seven trims across two battery options, with bookings now open through its website and dealerships nationwide. The launch strengthens Kia's push in India's fast-growing EV market, where buyers are increasingly looking beyond range alone and toward technology, convenience and long-term ownership value.

Israel’s strikes kill dozen people in Gaza

WAFAA SHURAF/ SAMY MAGDY/ SAM METZ
■ Deir al-Balah

Israeli airstrikes have killed at least a dozen people in Gaza over the past two days, local health officials said on Wednesday, as strikes continue almost daily despite a months-old ceasefire with Hamas.

On Wednesday, three members of a family were killed in central Gaza, Al Aqsa Hospital officials said. On Tuesday, a woman and six police officers were among those killed in an airstrike on a police station in the densely populated Jabaliya refugee camp in northern Gaza, hospital officials said.

A man died in the bombing of a tent camp in Khan Younis in the south, Nasser Hospital officials said.



And Israeli forces shot and killed a child in the Muwasi area outside the southern-most city of Rafah, according to hospital officials. The Israeli military did not immediately comment on the strikes in central and southern Gaza. In a statement on the attack in Jabaliya, it claimed that four of the slain police officers were Hamas militants, without providing evidence on how those killed

were involved in planning or carrying out attacks.

One of the officers, Col. Mohamad Marwan Salem, was a senior police commander and head of the Jabaliya police station, the Hamas-run Interior Ministry said. Hamas, which ruled Gaza for years, maintains an armed wing as well as civilian police and security services that are overseen by its Interior Ministry.

Throughout the war, Israel has targeted local police, including those guarding humanitarian aid convoys.

Israel's military has claimed it considers police stations legitimate targets if they're "being used to advance military activities, or if those present are military operatives involved in advancing terrorist activities." It did not say what military activities it believed were taking place at the Jabaliya police station, nor did it provide evidence that attacks were being planned. Hamas says the police force is engaged in maintaining law and order. Israeli attacks on Gaza's police have been condemned by the United Nations human rights office, which said last month that police personnel had been attacked at least a dozen times in 2026, including

"during ordinary law enforcement operations, including directing traffic and patrolling streets and markets."

"The pattern of attacks raises concerns that Israeli forces apply no distinction between police personnel and fighters belonging to armed groups in Gaza," it said in a June 3 statement.

Guterman, a researcher at Israel's Institute for National Security Studies, said Israel's targeting suggests that it regards parts of Hamas' policing apparatus as closely integrated with its military infrastructure, including through dual-role personnel and the use of facilities for weapons storage, operations and logistics. The fragile ceasefire deal in October attempted to halt a two-year-long war between Israel and Hamas. (AP)

Indian tourists emerge among Sri Lanka’s highest daily spenders, says tourism chief

ASHOKE RAJ ■ Colombo

Indian travellers are contributing more to Sri Lanka's tourism economy than previously believed, with their average daily spending now exceeding that of the overall international visitor average, according to the country's top tourism official.

Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) Chairman Buddhika Hewawasam said Indian tourists currently spend an average of US\$154 per day, compared to the national average of US\$148 per foreign visitor. The figures challenge the long-held perception that Indian tourists are relatively low spenders.

Addressing a media briefing, Hewawasam said the Indian market has evolved significantly, with visitors increasingly opting for premium travel experiences. He noted that Indian tourists now outspend travellers from several European countries on a daily basis. To build on this trend, Sri Lanka has expanded its promotional campaigns across India, moving beyond its traditional focus on southern states. Tourism authorities are now targeting emerging markets in Gujarat, including Ahmedabad and Rajkot, while maintaining outreach in Mumbai, New Delhi and southern India. The island nation is also strengthening its appeal among affluent Indian travellers by promoting luxury holidays, destination weddings and other high-value tourism segments. Officials believe these initiatives will help increase tourism revenue while diversifying the visitor base.

The renewed focus on India comes as Sri Lanka seeks to position itself as a premium tourism destination.



SRI LANKA SHOULD LEVERAGE ITS UNIQUE ATTRACTIONS—INCLUDING ITS WILDLIFE, BEACHES, HILL COUNTRY AND CULTURAL HERITAGE—TO ATTRACT HIGHER-SPENDING TRAVELLERS



—FORMER SRI LANKAN MINISTER PATALI CHAMPIKA RANAWAKA

tion in the Indian Ocean, capitalising on its cultural links, scenic diversity and proximity to the Indian market. Adding to the discussion on the country's tourism strategy, former Sri Lankan minister Patali Champika Ranawaka has advocated a shift from mass tourism to a high-value model that prioritises quality over visitor numbers.

He argued that Sri Lanka should leverage its unique attractions—including its wildlife, beaches, hill country and cultural heritage—to attract higher-spending travellers while ensuring sustainable growth.

Ranawaka also stressed the

need for greater transparency in the tourism sector through digital payment systems to reduce the informal economy and improve revenue collection. He further highlighted the potential for increased investment by Indian private companies in infrastructure and tourism-related projects, saying stronger regulatory frameworks would help unlock long-term economic opportunities.

Sri Lanka views India as one of its most important tourism source markets and expects premium offerings and expanded regional outreach to further strengthen arrivals and visitor spending in the coming years.

Indian sailor killed in MV GFS Galaxy attack: UAE Mission

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

An Indian sailor, who went missing after an attack on the MV GFS Galaxy cargo vessel off the coast of Oman, has died, the Indian Consulate in Dubai confirmed on Wednesday.

It said the Indian officials are closely coordinating with the UAE authorities and the shipping company to provide all possible assistance to the deceased sailor's family. "We express our deepest condo-



Herambh Karmarkar

lences at the tragic demise of an Indian national due to an attack on the commercial vessel MV GFS Galaxy on 12 July 2026," the mission said in a post on X. The attack on the

Cyprus-flagged MV GFS Galaxy on Sunday off the coast of Oman left one of its 11 Indian crew members missing. Ten Indian crew members of the vessel were rescued.

The missing Indian national, identified as 30-year-old Herambh Karmarkar from Pune, was a third engineer aboard the cargo vessel when it was attacked.

According to Gulf News, Karmarkar's family was informed by the shipping company on Tuesday evening that Oman's coast

guard had recovered his body, nearly 60 hours after he was reported missing.

"The Consulate is in touch with the bereaved family and is closely coordinating with the relevant UAE authorities and the shipping company to provide all possible support and assistance to the family," the Indian mission said.

"We are awaiting his mortal remains, which are currently with the Oman Navy. Herambh had been on the vessel for the last five months and was due to sign

off soon," his father-in-law Vivek Tandon said on Wednesday.

Karmarkar is survived by his wife, mother and younger sister. He had completed his marine engineering from the City of Glasgow College in the UK and had joined the merchant navy, Tandon added.

The attack came amid fresh hostilities between Iran and the US, with India reiterating that the targeting of commercial shipping and civilian infrastructure in the region must end.

Office of the Superintending Engineer

6th circle, P.W.D. Uttarkashi

E-Mail : sepwduki@rediffmail.com Tel./Fax No-01374-222127

Letter No.- 3012/56 M-06/2026 Date 15.07.2026

National Competitive Bid (E-Tendering)

On behalf of the Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand, Superintending Engineer 6th circle, PWD Uttarkashi invites item Rate Tender through e-tendering (Two bid system), for the following work. All the information regarding tender shall be available on web site <https://www.uktenders.gov.in> from dated 17.07.2026 at 05.00 PM.

S. N.	Name of work	Earnest money (In Lacs)	Tender Cost (in Rupees)	Validity of tender (days)	Completion period (Month)	Category of Contractor's
1	New construction work under state sector in district uttarkashi block chinyalisour Bangaon-Chapda-kaslana motor road phase-2 stage-1 work.	4.15	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	12	Registration in "C" Class or above for road works in P.W.D. Uttarakhand

भारतीय थल सेना

JOIN INDIAN ARMY AS AN OFFICER

www.joinindianarmy.nic.in

अधिकारी प्रविष्टियाँ

- निम्नलिखित कोर्सों के लिए आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं:-
 - 25वाँ अल्पकालिक सेवा कमीशन जे.ए.जी. कोर्स अप्रैल 2027, कानून में स्नातक पुरुष एवं महिला उम्मीदवारों के लिए।
 - 125वाँ अल्पसेवा कमीशन एन.सी.सी. विशेष भर्ती कोर्स (पुरुष) (युद्ध में हताहत सेना कर्मियों के आश्रित सहित) अप्रैल 2027 के लिए।
 - 125वाँ अल्पसेवा कमीशन एन.सी.सी. विशेष भर्ती कोर्स (महिला) (युद्ध में हताहत सेना कर्मियों के आश्रित सहित) अप्रैल 2027 के लिए।
- ऑनलाइन आवेदन निम्नलिखित अवधि तक खुले रहेंगे:-
 - जे.ए.जी. कोर्स - पुरुष एवं महिला - 17 जुलाई से 17 अगस्त 2026
 - एन.सी.सी. विशेष भर्ती कोर्स - पुरुष - 20 जुलाई से 20 अगस्त 2026
 - एन.सी.सी. विशेष भर्ती कोर्स - महिला - 21 जुलाई से 21 अगस्त 2026

OFFICER ENTRIES

- Applications are invited for the following courses:-
 - 125th Short Service Commission JAG Entry Scheme Course (Men & Women) Apr 2027 course for Law Graduates.
 - 125th Short Service Commission NCC Special Entry Scheme Course Apr 2027 for Men (including Wards of Battle Casualties of Army personnel).
 - 125th Short Service Commission NCC Special Entry Scheme Course Apr 2027 for Women (including Wards of Battle Casualties of Army personnel).
- Online applications will open as under:-
 - JAG Course - Men & Women - 17 July to 17 Aug 2026
 - NCC (Special) Course - Men - 20 July to 20 Aug 2026
 - NCC (Special) Course - Women - 21 July to 21 Aug 2026

नोट :-

- सेना में भर्ती पूर्णतः पारदर्शी और मुफ्त है। दलालों से सावधान रहें।
- विस्तृत नोटिफिकेशन और जानकारी के लिए, कृपया www.joinindianarmy.nic.in पर जाएं।

Note:-

- Recruitment in the Army is totally transparent and free. Beware of touts.
- For detailed Notification, please visit www.joinindianarmy.nic.in.



CBC 10601/11/0011/2627

SOUTH COAST RAILWAY

VISAKHAPATNAM

Follow us on @SCoRailway

Website: www.scorailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE No:

VSKP-TRS-RT-04-2026-27

Sr.DEE/TRS/VSKP acting for and on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders against Tender No VSKP-TRS-RT-04-2026-27 Closing Date/ Time 05.08.2026 @ 15:00 Hrs Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids upto closing date and time only. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender, and any such manual offer received shall be ignored.

Name of work with its location :

Filment of Trap Chamber in Three Phase locomotives (WAP-7 & WAG-9) for collecting coal/dust particles from BP train pipe during emergency brake application. Value of Tender (₹) : 11,14,606.55/- Earnest Money to be deposited : (₹) 22,360/- Cost of Tender Form : (₹) 2,360/- Address of the office : Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer (TRS) Electrical Loco Shed South Coast Railway NAD Post Visakhapatnam - 530 009 Completion period of the work : One year (12 months) Bidding system : Single packet system (e-tendering) Tender closing date and time : 05.08.2026 at 15.00 hrs Website particulars at : <http://www.ireps.gov.in>

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer SCORA078 (TRS)/Visakhapatnam

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in>

FORM NO. 5

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL

600/1, University Road,

Near Hanuman Setu Mandir,

Lucknow- 226007

(Area of Jurisdiction-Part of

Uttar Pradesh)

Summons for filing & Appearance by Publication

O.A. No. 695 /2025

Date 07/05/2026

[Summons to defendant under section 19(3) of the Recovery of Debts due to Banks and Financial Institutions Act, 1993 read with Rules 12 and 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure Rules, 1993)]

Original Application No. 695 of 2025

ICICI Bank Limited ...Applicant

Versus

Sahil Gupta & Others ...Defendants

To,

1. SAHIL GUPTA S/O SUDESH KUMAR GUPTA, R/o B-93, Sector-30 Noida, Delhi Public School, Noida, Gautamdh Nagar-201301, U.P.

In the above noted application, you are required to file in Paper Book form in two sets along with documents and affidavits (if any), personally or through your duly authorized agent or legal practitioner in this Tribunal, after serving copy of the same on the applicant or his counsel/duly authorized agent after publication of the summons, and thereafter to appear before the Tribunal on 02/09/2026 at 10:30 A.M. failing which the application shall be heard and decide in your absence.

Registrar

Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Vedant Chaudhary is the owner of the Residential house no. 7, area measuring 60 Sq. Yds i.e. 50.16 Sq. Mtrs, Out of Kharsa no. 395 situated in the colony Om Sai Garden in the Village Chipayana Bujing (Across Railway Line), Pargana & Tehsil Dadr & Diott, Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) through Gift Deed dated 02.05.2026 doc. no. 22133 executed by Mr. Ajit Singh in favour of Mr. Vedant Chaudhary in respect of residential house no. 7, area measuring 60 Sq. Yds i.e. 50.16 Sq. Mtrs, out of Kharsa no. 395.

Mr. Vedant Chaudhary intends to transfer the ownership of above said property by way of Transfer Deed to Suman Rai. Subsequently, Suman Rai is in the process of mortgaging the said plots with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7 days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Vertis: Nandan (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-0449971, e-mail: accounts@nvnorth.in

IN THE BOMBAY CITY CIVIL COURT AT BOMBAY

CHAMBER SUMMONS No. 1655 OF 2025

IN

S. C. SUIT No. 629 OF 2016

Jitendra M. NayyarApplicant / Plaintiff

IN THE MATTER BETWEEN:-

Jitendra M. Nayyar, Aged 80 years, Indian Inhabitant, Occupation: Retired, Karta and coparcener of the Lachmandas Tulsiaram Nayyar H.U.F. residing at Doon Valley Combors Pvt. Ltd., Mussorie Diversion Road, Malsi, Dehra Dun, Uttarakhand - 248003Plaintiff

VERSUS

1. Ravinder Kahanchand Nayyar Aged 57 years, Indian Inhabitant, Occupation: Business, residing at 18-A, Chinari Drive, Chattarpur, DLF Farms, New Delhi - 110074.

2. Yogesh Sureshchandra Agrawal Adult, Indian Inhabitant, Occupation: Business, residing at Flat No.11, Shiv Sadhana, C-Road, N. S. Bose Road, Marine Drive, Mumbai-400020Defendants

AND

1 (a) Rashi Ravinder Nayyar Age 33 years, Occ: Service

1 (b) Sahil Ravinder Nayyar Age 18 years, Occ: Student

All at 1(a) to 1(b) last residing at: 18-A, Chinari Drive, Chattarpur, DLF Farms, New Delhi-110074

Proposed Defendants

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that this Hon'ble Court will be moved before His Honour Judge Shri S.M. Bukke on 29th July, 2026, at 11:00 a.m. in the forenoon or soon thereafter when Counsel can be heard by the Court on part of the Plaintiff abovenamed, for the following reliefs:

(a) That the Plaintiff be permitted to delete the name of Ravinder Kahanchand Nayyar, Defendant No. 1 herein, who expired on 10th December 2023.

(b) That the Plaintiff be permitted to add the names of his heirs as Defendant No. 1(a) & 1(b) as mentioned in the attached Schedule.

(c) That ad-interim relief in terms of prayer (a) & (b) as stated hereinabove, be granted;

(d) for such further and other reliefs as this Hon'ble Court may deem fit and proper in the facts and circumstances of the present case;

(e) that the costs of this Chamber Summons be provided for.

Dated this 16th day of July, 2026.

This Chamber Summons has been taken out by

Mr. Bruno Castelli no.

Advocate for the Plaintiff,

Advocate Code: I-2780

Enrolment No: Mah/1337/2006

having his office at 1/10, Shram Sadhana, 1st Lane, Hindu Colony, Dadar (E), Mumbai - 400 014, E-mail: anbalegal@gmail.com

Mobile: +91 9820288610

BRUNO CASTELLI no.

Advocate for the Applicant / Plaintiff

To,

(1) Ms. Rashi Ravinder NayyarProposed Defendant No. 1(a)

(2) Mr. Sahil Ravinder NayyarProposed Defendant No. 1(b)

N.B: Please note that the Affidavit of Mr. Ajay J. Nayyar, the Constituted Attorney of the Plaintiff abovenamed, solemnly affirmed on 18th June 2025, will be used in support of this Chamber Summons.

Trump urges ICE to keep traffic stops despite new policy

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump says Immigration and Customs Enforcement should continue traffic stops after recent fatal shootings, seeming to contradict a new policy to halt them.

Trump wrote early Wednesday on his social media site ICE is "doing a GREAT job, one that has to be done." The Republican president says to remove criminals he says were let into the country under the previous Democratic administration "we must be strong, tough and smart and we CANNOT give up one of ICE's most important and effective Crime Fighting tools, THE TRAFFIC STOP!" Trump says, "Once we do, we are playing right into the criminal's hands."

The policy change came after an ICE officer shot and killed a Colombian driver Monday in Maine and a week after one shot and killed a motorist in Houston, renewing criticism of the agency's enforcement tactics that were widely condemned last winter after the killings of Alex Pretti and Renee Good in Minnesota.

In Florida on Tuesday, a third man in roughly a week died during an

encounter with immigration officers. This time, a 28-year-old man was killed after he was hit by a tractor trailer while running from immigration and other federal officers, authorities said. It's a narrative that has been repeated again and again since the Trump administration's immigration crackdown began, with federal officers confronting drivers then saying they opened fire when their vehicles became a danger.

That's despite decades of warnings from policing experts that shooting into moving cars presents a danger of its own and should almost always be avoided. At least 10 people have been killed during immigration operations since the start of the Trump administration's mass deportation campaign. At least four of those deaths involved people in vehicles.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Tender Notice No. DSL-TKD-Trap Chamber-26 Dated 14.07.2026

The Sr. DME/Diesel, Northern Railway, Diesel Loco Shed, Tughlakabad for and on behalf of President of India invites e-tenders for the following work. The tender will be accepted online only in the prescribed tender document.

Name

Provision of Trap Chamber for collecting coal/dust particles coming out of work from BP Train Pipe during emergency brake application in HHP locomotive

Place of work

Diesel Shed, Tughlakabad, New Delhi-110044.

Completion period

01 Year

Approximate cost of work

Rs. 2,59,389.60/- Including GST (Rs. Two Lakh Fifty Nine Thousand Three Hundred Eighty Nine and Sixty Paise only including GST)

Amount of Bid Security

Rs. 5,200/- (Rs. Five Thousand Two Hundred only)

Technical Eligibility Criteria

As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.

Financial Eligibility Criteria

As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.

Website to download and upload e-tender document

www.ireps.gov.in

Due date & time of uploading of Tender by tenderer

05.08.2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.

Date & Time of Tender opening

05.08.2026 after 12:00 Hrs.

Validity of offer

60 days from opening of tender.

Tender Document can be downloaded from Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. For details of work experience, scope of work and terms & conditions please see Tender document.

2444/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Ursula von der pledges EU support for Ukraine

HANNA ARHIROVA/BARRY HATTON
■ KYIV

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen went to Kyiv on Wednesday to mark Ukraine's annual Statehood Day, pledging continued military and financial support for the country's independence as it holds out against Russia's 4-year-old full-scale invasion.

Ukraine's sovereignty has been threatened since Russian forces occupied Ukraine's Crimea in 2014 and Moscow illegally annexed the peninsula, followed eight years later by the all-out invasion of February 2022. Statehood Day, celebrating the country's self-determination, is a public holiday in Ukraine.

The war has killed thousands of soldiers and civilians, forced mil-



Romania President Nicusor Dan, Moldova President Maia Sandu, EU Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and Olena Zelenska attend a ceremony in Kyiv

lions to flee their homes, reduced Ukrainian cities to rubble and fueled fears the confrontation could slide into an open conflict between Russia and NATO, whose member nations have supported Kyiv. No peace settlement is in

sight. Senior officials from southeastern European countries were also expected in Kyiv on Wednesday for a periodic gathering focused on Black Sea and regional security. Last year's meeting in the southern Ukrainian

city of Odesa reaffirmed the countries' support for Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has recently won important pledges of further support, including from the Group of Seven leading industrialised nations and the so-called Coalition of the Willing countries.

Von der Leyen, the European Union's top official, said her trip to the Ukrainian capital was her 11th in wartime. Europe is watchful of Russia's broader intentions on the continent and has provided billions of euros (dollars) to Ukraine as well as diplomatic support.

Von der Leyen said she would announce new steps toward integrating the European and Ukrainian defence industries as well as providing new help to prepare Ukrainian air defences for

next winter, when Russia usually tries to knock out the power.

Her visit came as Western officials and analysts say Ukraine's increasingly frequent and accurate drone and missile attacks are hitting high-profile targets deep inside Russia, severely disrupting the Russian army's supply lines and causing civilian fuel shortages. "It's a special moment," Von der Leyen said of her visit on social media. "Ukraine has built a strong military momentum. The tide is turning." Meanwhile, Serbia's Moscow-friendly president, Aleksandar Vucic, was taking part in the Southeast Europe Summit in Kyiv.

Serbia, which relies almost fully on Russia for its energy supplies, has refused to join Western sanctions on Moscow that were imposed after its invasion,

although it officially supports Ukraine's territorial integrity.

Ukrainian officials said on Wednesday that at least eight civilians were killed and 11 others were injured in Russian aerial attacks. mRussian forces dropped six powerful glide bombs, mostly targeting infrastructure in Ukraine's northern Sumy region, killing three people and wounding seven, the head of the regional military administration, Oleh Hryhorov, said. Three people were killed and three others wounded in a Russian attack on Odesa, according to the head of the city's military administration, Serhii Lysak.

Ukraine's northern Chernihiv region, Russian drone attacks killed two people and seriously wounded an 18-year-old, regional military administration head, Viacheslav Chaus said. (AP)

India conveys condolences to Qatar as Rijiju meets Amir Sheikh Tamim



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Doha

Union Minister Kiren Rijiju has conveyed condolences on behalf of the government and people of India to Qatar's Amir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani on the demise of his father, former Amir Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani.

Rijiju, the Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs, travelled to Doha on Tuesday to convey condolences on behalf of India on the demise of Father Amir, who ruled Qatar for 18 years before abdicating in 2013. He died on July 12 at the age of 74.

Rijiju also conveyed personal regards of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the Qatari Amir, the Indian Embassy in Qatar said in a post on X.

"Father Amir was instrumental in building modern Qatar and a great friend of India who will be remembered for his invaluable contribution to building our bilateral relationship," the Ministry of External Affairs said earlier in a post on X.

India had declared one-day national mourning on July 13 as a mark of respect, with the national flag flown at half-mast throughout the country.

Confirmed Ebola cases top 2,000 in Congo, including 754 deaths



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bunia

Confirmed cases of Ebola in Congo have reached 2,011, including 754 deaths, according to Government data released overnight in what authorities say is the fastest-growing outbreak on record even as some health workers have gone on strike over payment issues. A total of 753 people remain in isolation or in hospitals, while 366 have so far recovered, according to data from Congo's Ministry of Health. Contact tracing remains a challenge, with coverage of those exposed still at 67 per cent.

The Central African nation has been battling the Ebola outbreak caused by the rare Bundiugyo virus since May 15. Two months since the onset, the outbreak continues to spread faster than health officials can track despite an expanding response. At least 80 per cent of new cases are emerging from unknown chains of transmission, the World Health Organisation said.

A key challenge is that health authorities have yet to identify the outbreak's patient zero, while displacements from armed conflict as well as mining-related movements have made it difficult to trace thousands who have come in contact with infected individuals.

Many of the newly reported deaths are people who died in their communities without ever reaching a health facility and without receiving care, Dr Chikwe Ihekweazu, the WHO health emergencies chief, said Tuesday after returning from Bunia in Ituri, the worst-hit province in the outbreak.

Health workers are also going on strike in different parts of Ituri. Some have told The Associated Press they have not received any payment since they started work at the onset of the outbreak.

Response efforts have also been challenged by the lack of approved vaccines or treatments for the Bundiugyo virus, unlike the more common Zaire virus for which there is a vaccine and which was responsible for most of Congo's past 16 outbreaks of the disease. Enrollment for a highly anticipated study of two possible Ebola treatments recently kicked off in Ituri.

India, EU to start negotiations on Delhi's association with Horizon Europe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Belgium

India and the European Union on Wednesday agreed to start formal negotiations on Delhi's association with Horizon Europe, the 27-member bloc's key funding programme for research and innovation, and launch a bilateral startup partnership focused on deep tech clean technologies.

During the 3rd EU-India Trade and Technology Council (TTC) meeting, attended by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, and Minister of State for Electronics and IT Jitin Prasada, the two sides also reviewed progress on digital connectivity and strategic technologies; clean and green technologies; and trade, investment and resilient value chains, said a press release.

"We will be starting negotiations for India's association with the Horizon Europe programme. It is also worth noting that joint research calls in areas like waste-to-green hydrogen, combating marine pollution and EV battery recycling are now at a pilot-scale validation and will hopefully go beyond," Jaishankar said.

A joint statement issued after the meeting said the two sides are poised to commence formal negotiations on India's association with Horizon Europe, the EU's flagship EUR 93.5 billion research and innovation funding programme, to conclude these before the end of 2026.

"This is a historic and strategic shift towards a long-term institutional framework of cooperation between both sides, which will allow Indian researchers and innovators to fully participate in the programme as from



2027," it added. The EU side was represented by European Commission Executive Vice-President for Tech Sovereignty, Security and Democracy Henna Virkkunen, Commissioner for Trade and Economic Security, Interinstitutional Relations and Transparency Maros Sefcovic and Commissioner for Startups, Research and Innovation Ekaterina Zaharieva.

"When Europe and India innovate together, we don't just develop new technologies—we shape the future. By bringing India closer to Horizon Europe and connecting nearly half a million startups, we are building a partnership designed to turn shared ambition into global impact," said Zaharieva.

Underlining the growing ambition of the EU-India strategic partnership, both sides agreed to strengthen work on resilient value chains in agri-food, active pharmaceutical ingredients and clean energy technologies.

The two sides decided to launch an EU-India Startup Partnership focused on deep tech clean technologies and establish the first EU-India Innovation Hub on electric vehicle charging technologies and testing. They also agreed to

step up cooperation on semiconductors, high-performance computing, quantum technologies, artificial intelligence and 6G.

The meeting took stock of joint research supported by 60 million euros over four years, including projects on waste-to-hydrogen, marine pollution and electric vehicle battery recycling.

The two sides also reaffirmed their support for the multilateral trading system and World Trade Organisation (WTO) reform.

"The EU-India partnership has led to many fruitful exchanges on AI, semiconductors, interoperability of digital trust services and startups," said Virkkunen. "Together with India, we will continue pursuing the common objectives to promote secure, trusted and resilient technology."

The EU-India TTC was established in April 2022 by President von der Leyen and Prime Minister Narendra Modi to address challenges in the areas of trade, trusted technology and security, while deepening their cooperation.

The first meeting of the EU-India TTC took place in May 2023, while the second took place in February 2025.

Leaving UK in better shape: Starmer at final Parliament session as PM

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Keir Starmer wrapped up his final Prime Minister's Questions (PMQs) session in the lower house of the UK Parliament on Wednesday with an emotional farewell and standing ovation from the Government benches.

The 63-year-old Labour MP, who announced his resignation last month and has been serving as caretaker until the party leader is elected, said he was leaving Britain in a better place than he found it and expressed "wholehearted support" for his successor.

Andy Burnham, the former mayor of Greater Manchester, is on course to take charge as the new British prime minister next week after being endorsed by a resounding 349 Labour MPs in the leadership race. "I'm proud to leave this country in a better shape than I found it; I am proud of everything that we have achieved," Starmer told MPs in the House of Commons as he concluded



PMQs with "goodbye."

"Every Prime Minister knows when they take up the torch that the day will come when they have to pass it on. That day has come for me. This is the end of my political journey. In six years, we went from historic defeat in 2019 to historic victory in 2024," he said.

During a largely good-natured final parliamentary clash across the despatch box, Starmer reflected upon his legacy as someone who had "picked up" the Labour Party from electoral oblivion to win a "landslide" general election in July 2024. (PTI)

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Saurabh Kalia S/o Arun Kumar R/o Q-45, Double Story, Lajpat Nagar-4, Delhi-24, informs that my owned property G-7B, GF, Building No. 56, Nehru Place, area measuring 100 Sq.Ft. both original Agreement to Sell & General Power of Attorney accidentally destroyed due to household reasons and are now irretrievable. Contact: 9811908172

PUBLIC NOTICE

"It is informed to public at large that my client Indian Overseas Bank, Rohini Sector-9 branch Delhi informed the undersigned that one of its customers namely Smt. Sarita intends to purchase Flat No. 54/0801, measuring 1264 sq. fts., situated in Kingsbury Apartment, TDI City, Kundli, District-Sonepat, Haryana and she also represented that the Original Regd. Conveyance Deed No. 635 dt. 02.05.2019 executed by TDI Infrastructure Limited, in favour of Sh. Sanjay Kumar Garg son of Sh. ChhabilDass Gupta in respect of above said flat has been misplaced/lost from its present owner Mr. Alankrit Garg son of Sh. Ajay Kumar Garg and the same could not be found despite best efforts and thus the same may be treated as lost documents. Any Persons, Banks, Financial Institutions having claiming any rights, title, interests, lien, charge, mortgages etc., in the above captioned property or has any sorts of disputes, litigations, and or any objection for its proposed Sale/mortgage by my client's customers should contact or notify the same (with valid documentary proof) to my client Indian Overseas Bank, Rohini Sector-9 branch, Delhi-110085 through its branch manager Mr. Vyom Raj, Senior Manager Mobile No. 9997423774 within 15 days from the date hereof, failing which it shall be presumed that the above captioned property is free from all sorts of encumbrances (of any nature) and the above said proposed borrowers/buyers/mortgagor shall proceed to complete the sale/purchase transaction of the said property and thereafter the Bank shall proceed further to complete the creation of an equitable mortgage over the captioned property."

Asha Ram Verma (Advocate),
Resi.-cum-Office YP-62-A, Ground Floor, YP-Block, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, Mobile No. 9810516149.

VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD

Unit 203 & 204, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Navbharat Estate, Zakaria Bunder Road, Sewri (West), Mumbai 400015. Maharashtra. CIN No.: U65922MH2005PLC272501

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower / Co-Borrower/ Mortgagor (s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited the same shall be referred herein after as Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited. The Secured Assets will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" basis through E-Auction. It is hereby informed to General public that we are going to conduct public E-Auction through website <https://sarfaesi.auctiontigger.net>

S N	Account No. and Name of borrower, co-borrower, Mortgagors	Date & Amount as per Demand Notice U/s 13(2) & Date of Physical Possession	Descriptions of the property/Properties	Reserve Price, Earnest Money Deposit (In Rs.)	E-Auction Date and Time, EMD Submission Last Date, Inspection Date
1	HL0000000141905 Wazir Khan (Borrower), Chandani (Co-Borrower)	Demand Notice Date 23-Jul-2025 & Amt Rs. 2900431/- as on 9-Jul-2025 + Interest Cost etc. & 27-Apr-2026	Property No. 19, First Floor (Front Side, RHS Portion, Without Roof Rights), Area 75 Sq. Yrds., Out of Khasha No. 362 Situated in Village Nawada, Colony Known As Mohan Garden, Block- RK, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, New Delhi, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, National Capital Territory Of Delhi, 110059, India	Rs.190000/- Rs.190000/-	31-07-2026 Timings 10:00 AM to 12:00 PM, 30-07-2026 up to 5:00 PM., 23-07-2026

1. All Interested participants / bidders are requested to visit the website <https://sarfaesi.auctiontigger.net>. For details, help, procedure and online training on e-auction, prospective bidders may contact M/S e-Procurement Technologies Pvt. Ltd. (Auctiontigger); Address : Head Office: B-705, Wall Street II, Opp. Orient Club, Near Gujrat College, Ellis Bridge, Ahmedabad – 380 006 Gujrat (India). Contact Person : Mr. Ram Sharma Contact number: 8000023297/9265562618/9265562821/079-6813 6842/6869. email id: ramprasada@auctiontigger.net, support@auctiontigger.net
2. For further details on terms and conditions please visit <https://sarfaesi.auctiontigger.net> to take part in e-auction.
3. For more details about the property kindly contact to Authorized officer. Raman Joshi/Sorabh Pahwa Contact no.7838293620/9216986668
THIS IS ALSO A STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES,2002

Date : 16.07.2026
Place : Uttam Nagar

Authorised officer
Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd

NORTHERN RAILWAY

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION

Senior Divisional Commercial Manager/Freight, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. 2022/TC(FM)/10/04 dated 13.06.2022, and Railway Board's letter no.2024/RS(G)/779/7(E3471089) 13.08.2024 invites bids through e-Auction (www.ireps.gov.in) for leasing of parcel space of SLR compartments and VPs (on round trip basis) for a period of three years as per detail and schedule given below:

S. No	Date & time of e-Auction	Assets to be auctioned
1	22.07.2026 at 10:30 am	01 LVPH (24 tonnes) on round trip basis in each train-12454/12453, 14012/14011, 14050/14049 & 20408/20407.
2	24.07.2026 at 10:30 am	12005(F1), 12011(F1), 12013(F1), 12015(F1), 12034(F1) (Mon, Wed, Thu, Fri, Sat), 12045(F1), 12304(F1), 12428(F1), 12481(F1, R1), 12802(F1), 12826(R1), 14152 (F1), 14208(F1), 14212(F1), 15530(F1), 15622(F1), 20504(F1), 22168(F1), 22210(F1).
3	27.07.2026 at 10:30 am	12017 (F1), 12040 (F1), 12055 (F1), 12057 (F1), 12282 (F1), 12350 (F1), 12382(F1), 12442 (F1), 12444(F1), 12448 (F1), 12455(F1), 12528(F1, R), 12963(F1), 13066(F1), 13252(F1), 20452 (F1), 22406(F1), 22421 (F1), 22454 (F2).
4	28.07.2026 at 10:30 am	12034 (F1) (TUE), 12060(F1), 12265(F1), 12596(F1), 12918(F1), 14014(F1), 14056 (R1), 14164 (F), 14341(F1), 14679(F1), 14681 (F1,R1), 15035 (F1,F2,R1), 15280 (F1, R1), 19404(F1, R1), 22404(F1), 22950(F1).
5	29.07.2026 at 10:30 am	12212(R1),12226(F1), 12457(F1,F2,R1), 12498(R1) (Sun, Fri, R), 14303 (F1,F2,R1), 15304(F1,F2,R1), 20473(F1), 22429(F1), 22438(F1,R1), 22472(F1), 22542(F1).
6	30.07.2026 at 10:30 am	12274(F1), 12436(F1), 12648 (F1), 12966(F1), 14331 (F1,F2,R1), 14507 (F1,F2,R1), 14731(F1,R1), 15116 (F1), 22410(F1), 22420(F1), 22421 (F2,R1), 22454 (F1,R1).

Important notes: 1. For more information, requirement and various aspects regarding these e-Auctions, interested bidders are advised to visit https://www.ireps.gov.in/html/helpdesk/learning_centre.html. (e- Auction leasing section). 2. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute rights to short terminate these contracts at any point of time and/or for taking any decision regarding the discontinuation/ continuation of these contracts with modified/additional terms and conditions depending upon the continuation/discontinuation of these trains or commencement of new train services.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2431/26

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	NEW PLANTATION AND MAINTENANCE OF WORKS IN SIRSA DABWALI RANGE UNDER NHAJ SCHEME	14.07.2026 22.07.2026	99.71 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416067122 forest_srsa@yahoo.com
2	BPS GOVERNMENT MEDICAL COLLEGE FOR WOMEN KHANPUR KALAN SONPAT	REGARDING PUBLISHING OF ADVERTISEMENT FOR TENDER FOR PROCUREMENT OF ITEM I.E. FALSE CELLING + SIX WORKS.	16.07.2026 23.07.2026	EMD 70000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416803361 bpsgmc.purchase@gmail.com
3	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 437 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 437 ITEMS)*.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
4	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 01 ITEM I.E. SPECTROMETER (SINGLE LOT OF 01 ITEM)*.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
5	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 34 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 34 ITEMS)*.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
6	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 25 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 25 ITEMS)*.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
7	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 22 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 22 ITEMS)*.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
8	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 01 TO 03 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 03 ITEMS) *.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
9	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	DESCRIPTION OF STORE:- LIST COMPRISING OF ITEMS FROM SR. NO. 1 TO 13 ITEMS (SINGLE LOT OF 13 ITEMS) *.	16.07.2026 19.08.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in **RO 47210-I-27-7**

Assam’s war on drugs: Taking the fight to Golden Triangle’s doorstep



SABIR NISHAT

With narcotic substances worth more than 73,253 crore seized since 2021, Assam has emerged as India’s frontline in the battle against transnational drug trafficking. The recent BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies meeting in Guwahati has further underscored the strategic importance of the Northeast in combating the illicit drug trade emanating from the notorious Golden Triangle. Yet, experts caution that seizures alone cannot win a battle that is as much about organised crime, border security and public health as it is about law enforcement.

When Assam Police intercepts a consignment of heroin or methamphetamine tablets on a highway or in a border district, the seizure represents far more than another successful police operation. It is one link in a much larger struggle against transnational criminal networks whose reach extends from clandestine laboratories in Myanmar to markets across South Asia.

The figures released by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma offer a glimpse into the scale of that battle.

Since 2021, Assam has registered 16,605 cases under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, arrested 26,537 persons and seized narcotic



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma drives a road roller while attending the state level drugs disposal programme at 14th Assam Police Battalion, Daulasal, Nalbari

KOMOL LOSON TALUKDAR

substances valued at more than 73,253 crore. Calling the campaign Mission Assam Against Drugs, Sarma described the results as evidence of a sustained offensive driven by intelligence-based policing and coordinated enforcement.

“Our relentless war against drugs is delivering decisive results,” the Chief Minister said, reiterating the government’s resolve to continue the crackdown until organised trafficking networks are dismantled. Geography has made Assam both strategically important and uniquely vulnerable. The Northeast shares nearly 1,900 kilometres of international border with Myanmar, while the region also connects with Bangladesh, Bhutan and China. This location has transformed the region into a crucial transit corridor linking South Asia with Southeast Asia. For decades, traffickers have exploited these routes to transport heroin, opium and, increasingly, synthetic narcotics.

Much of this illicit trade

originates in the Golden Triangle-the mountainous border region shared by Myanmar, Laos and Thailand. Once infamous primarily for opium cultivation, the region has in recent years evolved into one of the world’s largest production centres for methamphetamine and other synthetic drugs.

International agencies have repeatedly warned that organised criminal syndicates operating in the Golden Triangle have diversified production, expanded distribution networks and adopted increasingly sophisticated methods to evade law enforcement.

Political instability in Myanmar following the military takeover in 2021 has further aggravated the challenge. Police arrested 4,175 persons in drug-related cases in 2021. By 2025, annual arrests had risen to 4,901. During the same period, the value of narcotics seized increased from 7383.64 crore to 7473.46 crore.

The seizures include heroin, methamphetamine

tablets popularly known as Yaba, cannabis and other psychotropic substances.

The narcotics problem confronting the Northeast extends well beyond trafficking. States such as Manipur, Mizoram and Nagaland have witnessed growing concerns over drug abuse, particularly among young people. Drug trafficking has also become intertwined with other forms of organised crime, including money laundering, arms smuggling and human trafficking. The recent BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies meeting held in Guwahati assumed particular significance.

The choice of Assam’s largest city as the venue reflected India’s recognition that the Northeast has become central to the regional fight against narcotics trafficking.

The meeting concluded with the adoption of the Guwahati Declaration, which calls for enhanced intelligence sharing, coordinated investigations, operational cooperation and stronger collective action against illicit drug trafficking, precursor chemicals, synthetic narcotics and transnational organised crime.

Sarma has expressed confidence that the Guwahati Declaration will complement Assam’s ongoing anti-drug campaign by strengthening cooperation against cross-border trafficking syndicates.

The writer is Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal

FICCI launches Family Office Forum to unlock \$30 billion in patient capital for start-ups

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry (FICCI) on Wednesday launched the ‘Family Office Forum’ - a platform for family offices - with the aim of channelling a growing pool of family capital, estimated at over \$30 billion across roughly 300 family offices in India, into country’s start-up ecosystem. The launch, themed “Role of Family Offices in India’s Start-up Ecosystem,” brought together representatives from family offices, venture capital firms, industry to chart roadmap for closer collaboration between India’s capital pools and its start-up economy.

Sanjeev Bikhchandani, Chair, FICCI Start-up Committee & Founder and Executive Vice-Chairman, Info Edge, said, “Family offices represent a significant and growing segment of capital in India, but their needs have simply not been well served - they’ve historically been clubbed together with venture capital firms, even though their experience, regulations, investment strategies, and taxation issues are quite distinct. As India prospers, family offices are only going to get larger and more specialized, and that calls for a dedicated platform where they can exchange ideas and work together. Family offices are emerging as a serious, professional source of capital for the country’s economic growth - that’s the thinking behind this first dedicated Forum.”



Sanjeev Bikhchandani

During the session Forum’s vision, objectives, and roadmap were highlighted. Family offices in India are rapidly increasing in number and becoming crucial investors in start-ups and private markets, bringing patient capital and a strategic approach to innovation. Yet the members have consistently flagged the same challenges - limited co-investment opportunities, duplication of effort from separate due diligence, and no single platform for deal discovery, learning, or networking. The FICCI Family Office Forum is designed to address exactly this - a network, a marketplace, and a policy voice, all in one.

Bhavesh K Jatania, Head - Start-up Banking, IDFC FIRST Bank, addressing the session, noted, “India has created substantial capital over the last two decades — an estimated \$30 billion sits with roughly 300 family offices today - but there hasn’t been an organised way to channel it into our innovation ecosystem. What’s been missing is the bridge: family offices struggle to find quality deals

and lack a unified voice, while start-ups struggle to reach the right investors and build credibility for patient, longer-gestation bets. At IDFC FIRST Bank, we see ourselves as a growth partner to start-ups at every stage, and platforms like this Forum are exactly the bridge this ecosystem needs.” Tripti Singhal Somani, Co-Chair, BRICS Women’s Business Alliance (WBA) - Innovative Development Group & Founder, Womeninnovator, said, “Family offices must see themselves not just as wealth creators, but as trustees for the nation’s future - India’s start-up ecosystem is entering a phase where it needs patient capital, strategic mentorship, and long-term partnership, not just funding. I want to thank FICCI for convening this gathering of visionaries who are committed to both wealth and value creation.”

The launch was followed by two panel discussions - ‘Family Offices’ Perspective - Investing in Indian Start-ups: Opportunities, Challenges & Expectations’, moderated by Archana Jahagirdar, Founder and Managing Partner, Rukam Capital, with panellists from Artha Group, Bardia Family Office, Eraya Capital, Ashok Goyal Family Office, Berger Paints, DS Group, and SAR Group; and Raising Capital from Family Offices & Co-investment with VCs: Experience & Expectations’, moderated by Amarjeet Singh Makhija, Partner, Market Lead Advisory - Startups and Unicorns, PwC, with panellists from Beconext VC, YourNest Venture Capital, Dallas Venture Capital, and RPSG Capital Ventures.

Harivansh unveils landmark book on 75 years of democracy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha Harivansh, unveiled the book 75 Years of Indian Democracy: The Indian Election Story in Facts & Figures (1950-2025) at his official residence in New Delhi. He also released the inaugural issues of two peer-reviewed quarterly journals-the Indian Journal of Electoral Studies (IJES) and the Indian Journal of Socio-Economic Studies (IJSES).

Published by Indiatat Publications, the book presents a comprehensive chronicle of India’s electoral journey from 1950 to 2025, tracing the constitutional, institutional, and political evolution of the Republic. Harivansh appreciated initiatives that promote serious research, documenta-



tion and evidence-based scholarship. He observed that comprehensive works documenting India’s democratic evolution serve as valuable reference resources for researchers, policymakers and future generations.

Dr R K Thukral, Director, Indiatat Publications, and Editor of the book and both journals, said the initiative reflects Indiatat Publications’ commitment to making authentic electoral and socioeconomic data and research readily accessible to the research community, policymakers, academic institutions and the wider public.

CIABC welcomes India-UK trade deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC) welcomed the historic trade agreement between India and the UK which came into effect from July 15. CIABC Director General Anant S Iyer said that it is a huge opportunity for both nations. Anant S Iyer said, “Alcoholic beverages is an important component in the India-UK trade. We hope that the FTA will lead to enhanced cooperation, sharing of technical knowhow and sharing of best practices that will help in the growth of the alcobev industry. We also hope that the FTA will drive investments into India and also help Indian companies which are looking for investments in the UK.

Lower import duty on



CONFEDERATION OF INDIAN ALCOHOLIC BEVERAGE COMPANIES

Scotch whisky will help Indian alcobev manufacturers to balance their input costs especially in the light of escalation of costs of dry goods, higher cost of logistics and production as well as rupee devaluation due to the US-Iran conflict. Moreover, phased reduction in import duty over a period of 10 years will give ample time to the domestic industry to gear up to the challenges and dynamics of the evolving marketplace.”

He further said that it is for the individual companies to decide on whether prices will be reduced given the duty cut and benefit passed onto consumers.

REC Limited signs MoU with CPRI to strengthen quality assurance under RDSS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

REC Limited, a ‘Maharatna’ company under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Central Power Research Institute (CPRI) on Tuesday at Corporate Office, Gurugram, to strengthen quality testing and assurance mechanisms for materials deployed under the



Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS).

The MoU was signed by Yogendra Singh, GM & HoD of

PMD Quality, REC and MG Anandakumar, Joint Director (BD & CBS Division), CPRI. The signing ceremony was accord-

ed by the presence of Prince Dhawan, IAS, Executive Director (PMD), REC, Dr Neha Adhikari, Joint Director, CPRI, and in the presence of officials from both organisations. Under the agreement, REC and CPRI will collaborate for third-party quality testing of RDSS project materials, technical support, capacity-building initiatives, and development of robust quality frameworks.

The writer is Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (15.7.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | JULY 16, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

1 Experimental new trail (5)

2 Cause to argue? (6)

3 Female deadlier than the male (6)

4 Stable type? (3)

5 Take the wrong way (5)

6 Specimens current in a less unusual case (7)

7 Work is fun! (4)

8 Mount a camel outright! (6)

12 Erica's land (5)

13 One well held, sir? (5)

14 A professional stand-in (5)

15 Group of people in a plane crash! (5)

19 Moves to make the coffee go round (5)

20 Grab a car part (6)

22 Just a piece of wire to me (4)

24 Burger ingredient! (3)

25 Conditionally released to take part in protection (7)

26 Handle with generosity (5)

27 Sag like a broken door needing a bit of paint (5)

28 The vessel a bachelor's in (5)

29 In command, he's vague (7)

30 Half a mile in the car free of jams (5)

31 High-speed checkers (5)

16 More in VAT (5)

18 Hugely distinguished (5)

19 Go and break a scraper (7)

21 Hardy associate (6)

22 Spirits of the chap with more about him (6)

23 Wild area in foreign parts (6)

25 Trimmed some of the drapes, possibly (5)

26 To reduce the gas, you need a mantle (4)

28 Extra decoration in a pub (3)

10

13

17

20

24

27

30

1

4

7

10

13

16

19

22

25

28

31

2

5

8

11

14

17

20

23

26

29

3

6

9

12

15

18

21

24

27

30

verka

THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD.
SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX NO. 0172-5041812,66

Notice Inviting Tender

www.verka.coop

Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-

Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Head Office, Chandigarh Providing and Fixing of interlocking paving tiles alongwith construction of sewer lines at Verka Sangrur Dairy.	Eight Months
2.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy a) Supply of equipment's for 6TPD powder installed (including design, supply, installation, testing, commissioning & integration with exiting setup complete in all respects). b) Rate Contract of advertisement material.	One complete job One year and extended upto three months
3.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy a) Pest control service at Verka Ludhiana Dairy including DIET project GADVASU, Milk chilling centres and Godowns. b) Labour contract for loading/ unloading of SMP/WMP bags, WMP Tins, Ghee and butter cartons etc. c) Supply of flex banners, flex boards, glow sign boards, vinyl stickers, vinyl with eco solvent printing, sun board and one way vision, shop/wall/vehicle painting etc. d) Hiring of vehicles (Tampoo/ Trucks) for supply of Verka Milk Products/Ghee/SMP etc. between Verka Ludhiana Dairy and Stations. e) Job contract for filling, packing and shifting of powder into 25 kg bags, ½ kg and 1 kg SMP and WMP packets, packing of Ghee (All Variants), packing and shifting of White Butter box, packing of Dahi (All Variants) and shifting to incubation room/ cold store. (including DIET, GADVASU).	14 No's 04 No's
4.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy Disposal off the scrap material on annual basis.	01 Complete job in all respects
5.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy a) Replacement of tubes and side plate of shell and tubes of economizer of 5 TPH boiler installed. b) Press Notice for outsourcing of Verka Milk Bar at MCC Fg.Churrian.	Annual Annual
6.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy Supply, installation and commissioning of Automatic 4 head and PLC based 6/15 kg Jar/Tin Ghee Filling Machine.	One Job
7.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy a) Replacement of tubes and side plate of shell and tubes of economizer of 5 TPH boiler installed. b) Press Notice for outsourcing of Verka Milk Bar at MCC Fg.Churrian.	Complete Job Five Years
8.	For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Bhattian (Khanna) Purchase of Steam Coal.	Annual/ 400 MTs(+/- 10%)

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/13323

General Manager (Purchase)

BRIEFLY

Axar Patel in top-10 of ICC ODI rankings for all-rounders



Indian all-rounder Axar Patel entered the top-10 of the ICC ODI rankings for all-rounders, rising three positions to ninth in the latest list after his brilliant performance in the opening game against England in Birmingham.

Axar grabbed four wickets and scored a 52-ball 57 to be a key contributor to India's six-wicket win on Tuesday.

As a result, the spin bowling all-rounder also gained 18 spots in the batting rankings to sit at 73, and rose up two spots in the bowling charts to be 42nd. The Indian team was boosted by the return of Shubman Gill, Jasprit Bumrah, Rohit Sharma, and Virat Kohli in the ODI format after losing the T20 series 0-4. Before he retired hurt at 80 off 75 balls, Gill smacked 11 fours and a six to set India well on track for their chase of 259 against England. The performance meant an increase in 12 rating points for Gill, and the batter is now merely 11 points away from Daryl Mitchell, who holds the top spot in the ODI batting rankings. Bumrah's stellar return, in which he picked up one wicket, added a sting to India's bowling and saw him back at 24th spot in the bowling rankings. Washington Sundar (52not out) was another notable performer and he gained 24 spots in the batting rankings (177th position) and 16 spots in the all-rounder rankings (55th spot). England's batting genius Joe Root was also among runs, and reached an equal 12th spot in Men's ODI Batting Rankings following a 76 off 76 balls. (PTI)

Ridhima takes lead in 10th leg of Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour



Ridhima Dilawari, who won three of the first six events this season, fired a bogey free four-under 68 to lead by one over three players after the first round of the tenth leg of the Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour here on Wednesday.

Ridhima, who was T-8 and T-9 in the last two legs, led by one over last week's winner Vani Kapoor, the experienced Amandeep Drall and Vidhatri Urs, who is looking to recover her form and rhythm. The trio shot three-under 69 and were chasing Ridhima hard. Saanvi Somu, who has been knocking on the doors of her first win on the Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour, first as an amateur and now as a pro, was all alone in the fifth place with 1-under 71. Ananya Datar and Kashika Misra carded even par 72 each to be tied for the sixth place, even as Mannat Brar and Riya Jadon shared the eighth place with 1-over 73 each. A big bunch of six players Prakruthi Sastry, Jasmine Shekar, Shagun Narain, Neha Tripathi and amateurs Ananthi Vivek and Ananyaa Sood shared the 10th place after carding two-over 74 each. Among the big names further behind were Tvesa Malik (75) in Tied-16th alongside young Lavanya Jadon. (PTI)

Lewandowski ready to provide big lift to the Chicago Fire

ANDY MARTINEZ ■ Chicago

Robert Lewandowski is looking forward to providing a big lift to the Chicago Fire as he is set to join Major League Soccer. The 37-year-old, who signed a two-year contract with the Fire, knew he didn't want to stay in Europe when his contract expired with Barcelona in May.

"I couldn't imagine myself with a different club besides Barcelona, so that's why we knew that the next step would be outside of Europe and of course, that it's not easy to move from Europe to USA, but we are very excited," Lewandowski said on Tuesday at an introductory news conference at the club's training facility. "But of

course, our lives are changing, but it's a new experience," Lewandowski scored 119 goals in 192 appearances for Barcelona.

He helped Barcelona win three La Liga championships in four seasons, including this year, and one title at Copa del Rey, Spain's national tournament. Lewandowski also has played a record 167 international games for Poland, beginning with a goal in his debut against San Marino in 2008, when he was 20. Lewandowski is Poland's all-time leading scorer with 89 goals. Lewandowski is a designated player, one of three roster spots that MLS teams carry that can exceed the salary cap. The Fire are scheduled to open

Climax Lawrence backs Spain to win World Cup

SANSKRITI GAUBA ■ New Delhi

Former India captain Climax Lawrence has tipped Spain to lift the FIFA World Cup after their commanding semifinal win over France, while backing Lionel Messi to steer defending champions Argentina past England in a hard-fought last-four clash.

La Furia Roja reminded everyone why they are the reigning European Champions as they produced a masterclass in control to defeat France 2-0 and book their place in the final.

"For me, Spain is going to win the World Cup. Whoever comes, England or Argentina,



Spain will win," Lawrence told PTI Videos in an exclusive interaction. The former midfielder praised Spain's tactical discipline, fitness and possession-based football, saying the European champions have looked the most complete side in the tournament. (PTI)

Mbappe denied 3rd straight World Cup final

SCHUYLER DIXON ■ Arlington (US)

Kylian Mbappe saw it for himself on the field: France simply didn't play well enough to reach a third consecutive World Cup final.

The France striker will have to settle for a third-place match and the continuing chase for another Golden Boot award in a tight race with Argentina superstar Lionel Messi.

Mbappe, one of the biggest stars of this year's World Cup and one of the game's greatest scorers, just couldn't generate many chances in his team's 2-0 loss to Spain in the semifinals on Tuesday.

Mbappe and Messi have

eight goals each so far at this year's tournament. Mbappe, who won the Golden Boot at the last World Cup four years ago in Qatar, holds the first tiebreaker with a 3-2 lead on assists. Messi and defending champion Argentina will play again on Wednesday in the other semifinal match against England.

Both players will then have one more match before the award is decided. France will play the loser of the other semifinal match in the third-place game on Saturday in Miami Gardens, Florida. Spain will take on the winner in East Rutherford, New Jersey, in the final.

"At the end of the day, you take all the glory when you



win," Mbappe said. "When you don't win ... it's part of the game. As the captain, I have to take all the responsibility, and I have no problem with that. We wanted to go to the final. We didn't go."

Mbappe had the fewest touches of any forward in the first half with 15. Perhaps his most prominent moment was trying to persuade referee Ivan Barton that the penalty resulting in Spain's

first goal shouldn't have been called. The foul by Lucas Digne on teenager Lamine Yamal stood, and Mikel Oyarzabal's penalty kick in the 22nd minute, put Spain ahead for good. Mbappe's best chance came in the 67th minute when his shot deflected off Spain defender Marc Cucurella and went just wide. La Roja already had a two-goal lead at that point.

"It's a team who loves to have control of the game, control of the ball," Mbappe said. "That's what we let them do. We let the midfield too much time to play, and at the end of the day they had quality to play. It's difficult when you don't change the play of Spain. We weren't at

the level to go to the final."

The 27-year-old Mbappe was issued a yellow card in the 86th minute when he rushed toward Unai Simon just as the Spain goalkeeper was bending over to pick up the ball. The two collided, sending Simon to the grass.

Mbappe started the match against Spain after exiting in the 77th minute of his team's 2-0 quarterfinal win over Morocco, when he scored his eighth goal of the tournament. Mbappe also scored eight goals four years ago in Qatar, where France lost to Messi and Argentina in a penalty shootout in the final. France beat Croatia to win the World Cup eight years ago in Russia. (AP)

Atiqa leaves behind Mercedes F1 juniors for pole position

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Viterbo (Italy)

India's 11-year-old racing prodigy Atiqa Mir gave another compelling example of her precocious talent by out-qualifying two Mercedes F1 junior drivers for pole position in the Champions of the Future Academy Program Round 3 in Viterbo.

Despite no testing on a rather technical Leopard Circuit, Atiqa, the first Indian to be backed by Formula 1 Academy, set sizzling pace in qualifying of the karting series. She beat established Mercedes F1 Junior drivers like Niccolo Perico of Italy and Devin Titz of



Germany for pole position besides setting an event record, earning the plaudits from one and all in the paddock.

Atiqa's special performance in qualifying came after she swept Round 2 of the COTFA series in Greece last month.

Post the stellar pole position, Atiqa secured P2 and P3 in the Heats after engrossing battles.

In the final, Atiqa started P2 and passed Niccolo for the lead. However, due to an engine mis-fire, she couldn't hold on to the lead and lost places finally before recovering to finish P6.

The results don't reflect Atiqa's sensational speed but she did make a mark with the audacious move for the lead on Lap 1 against Niccolo after outpacing him in qualifying.

On Day 2, Atiqa was hit by engine trouble and qualified 27th. The organisers were quick to change her engine but the damage was done by then.

Spain title favourite for World Cup

HIMANK NEGI/ HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Spain's tactical discipline, defensive solidity, and ability to adapt during matches have made them the team to beat at the FIFA World Cup, according to former India internationals, while opinion remains divided over who will join them in the final from Wednesday's blockbuster clash between England and Argentina.

Spain booked their place in the title clash with a commanding 2-0 victory over France, extending their tournament-best defensive record to six clean sheets while conceding just one goal in seven matches.



Kylian Mbappe and Ousmane Dembele were largely neutralised as Luis de la Fuente's side controlled proceedings with a blend of compact defending and fluid attacking play.

Former India captain and Khel Ratna awardee Shabbir Ali said Spain's ability to disrupt France's rhythm from

the outset proved decisive. "They completely cut down the supply line. They didn't allow the French midfield to create chances for Dembele and Mbappe. Once they controlled midfield, Spain had upper hand throughout," Ali told. The former striker was impressed by Spain's tactical flexibility. (PTI)

Spain and goalkeeper Unai Simon post another shutout to reach the WC final

STEPHEN HAWKINS ■ Arlington (US)

Spain goalkeeper Unai Simon sprinted off his line to beat a charging Kylian Mbappe to the ball with France desperately seeking a goal in the World Cup semifinals.

While Simon managed to get there first and head the ball away, he suddenly had the World Cup's co-scoring leader between him and the net with France forward Desire Doue trying to get control of the ball.

Even in that rare moment of chaos late in the match, the structured Spanish defense and the standout keeper again didn't allow a goal.

Spain ended up beating France 2-0 on Tuesday to advance to the World Cup final, 16 years after winning

the title the only other time the team made it that far at the tournament. It was the record sixth shutout for Spain at this year's expanded 48-team World Cup.

After the ball went directly to Doue off Simon's header, the keeper frantically sprinted back. Simon managed to turn his body to get his back to the net and made a leaping, no-hands deflection on the edge of the area. He then needed several strides before finally being able to fall on the ball. The latest shutout for Simon and Spain came against FIFA's top-ranked team, which had Mbappe coming into the match with 20 goals in his 20 World Cup games. The France captain was the Golden Boot winner in 2022, and his eight goals in this year's tourna-



ment are even with Argentina great Lionel Messi, the all-time leader with 21.

"We are very happy with the work that the team has done. Today we knew it would be a very complicated game with spectacular players, but I think we have them, too," Spain defender

Pau Cubarsi said in translated remarks. "We are a great family. We have helped each other for 90 minutes, we have pressed as never before." Mbappe had only three shots on Tuesday, none of them on target. France created no major scoring threats while missing out on

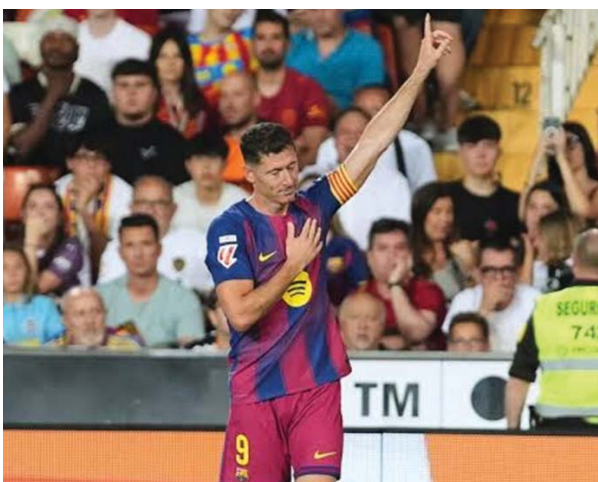
a chance to become only the third team to reach three consecutive World Cup finals.

"Spain has been able to defend well. I've watched all of their matches, and today they've done it very well," France coach Didier Deschamps said. "They've closed out all the spaces and also we've made some technical mistakes. So it is difficult to create problems when the technical level is below standard, especially compared to previous matches."

The only goal Simon has allowed in this tournament was Belgium's equalizer in the 41st minute of Spain's 2-1 quarterfinal victory. That snapped his World Cup record of 650 scoreless minutes. The semifinal match Tuesday came at the home of the NFL's Dallas Cowboys,

where eight days earlier in a round of 16 match Spain beat Portugal 1-0 for its record sixth consecutive World Cup match not allowing a goal. That included Simon stopping two shots by 41-year-old Cristiano Ronaldo, who was playing in the last of his six World Cups.

That World Cup shutout streak for Spain broke a tie with Italy (1990) and Switzerland (2006-10). It began with a 0-0 draw in the round of 16 in 2022, when Morocco advanced after a penalty shootout, and included a surprising scoreless draw against Cape Verde this year. Simon had surpassed the previous record of 517 consecutive scoreless minutes during a 3-0 blanking of Austria to open the knockout round. (AP)



McDonald's Park, a soccer-specific stadium, in 2028. "I see the potential to win titles with the new club,"

Lewandowski said. "I'm very happy because it's the new step in my career, the new step in my life. Now, we're in

a good position, but of course, we have to start working hard, and I also hope that we can enjoy after this season, a lot of what we achieved." Adding a player with the resume of Lewandowski was a no-brainer for Fire coach Gregg Berhalter. The team is in third place in the Eastern Conference as the league prepares to resume after its World Cup break this week. The Fire host the Vancouver Whitecaps on Thursday night, and Lewandowski could make his club debut then.

"This is a massive signing for our football club," Berhalter said. "We're excited to bring Robert to the club. We're excited to see how he can change the culture. "We have a good team

right now, I think Robert is a piece that can help take us to the top." Lewandowski is expected to form a strike partnership with Hugo Cuypers, who is the league's leading scorer with 13 goals.

"It's not too common to play with two strikers nowadays, but we've been working hard on what that looks like around the penalty box, what combinations look like, how to affect the back line with two strikers and we have some really good data points," Berhalter said.

"We've been scoring goals lately, we've been really picking apart the back line and we don't see any reason why that can't continue with Hugo and Robert on the field together." (AP)

India cap off successful campaign at Asian U-19 and U-23 Boxing Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jakarta

India ended their stellar campaign at the Asian U-19 and U-23 Boxing Championships with five gold, 10 silver, and four bronze medals across categories in Jakarta.

In the U-19 women's category, India secured two gold and six silver medals, underlining the depth of its youth programme.

Chandrika Bhores Pujari (51kg) delivered a dominant performance to clinch gold with a 5:0 win over Uzbekistan's Nazokat



Mardonova, while Prachi also secured gold with a convincing victory over Indonesia's Dira Artika.

India's other finalists in the U-19 category put up

strong fights but settled for silver.

In the U-23 women's category, India registered an equally impressive showing with one gold, four silver,

and four bronze medals.

Nisha (54kg) led the charge with a commanding 5:0 victory over Japan's Koin Kokufu to clinch gold. India's other gold medallists in the category continued their strong form to finish on top of the podium.

Meanwhile, Nikita Chand (60kg), Kajal (65kg), and Muskan (75kg) fought hard in their respective finals but settled for silver after facing strong opponents from Uzbekistan. The bronze medals came from semifinal finishes, further highlighting India's consistency across weight categories.

England coach Tuchel provides recipe to handle WC semifinals stress



JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

How does England coach Thomas Tuchel handle the pressure of a run to the semifinals of the World Cup?

Simple. A bike, a parking lot and an ice cream. Tuchel said ahead of England's World Cup semifinal against Lionel Messi's Argentina that he relaxes by reconnecting with his inner child. "Sometimes you just go on a bike and then you just need a big parking lot, an ice cream in your hand for 15 minutes on a bike and then you feel like you're 15 years old," Tuchel said Tuesday. "You enjoy your evening on a warm, summer evening for 15 minutes with the ice cream and you reconnect to the beauty of that feeling that we all have inside of us and that's sometimes all it needs." German coach Tuchel was hired in 2024 and charged with the responsibility of leading England to its first trophy since winning the World Cup in 1966.

He is one win away to leading the team to only its second World Cup final.

England plays defending champion Argentina in Atlanta on Wednesday and it would be understandable if Tuchel was feeling the pressure — especially coming up against Messi and resuming one of the fiercest rivals in soccer between the Three Lions and Argentina.

While he said the tournament had been draining due to traveling to Mexico and playing at altitude and also a "roller coaster" due to comeback wins against Congo and Norway, Tuchel also said the experience had been energizing. "I can tell you that it fuels me and it makes me feel alive," he said. "I love it so much that it gives me energy every day."

Tuchel, a serial trophy winner with Borussia Dortmund, Paris Saint-Germain, Chelsea and Bayern Munich, said he was grateful for the opportunity to coach at a World Cup. As for ending England's 60-year trophy drought? "I don't feel the burden," he said. "You feel the tension and I will be nervous and of course that is normal. But I feel no burden." (AP)

EDINBURGH

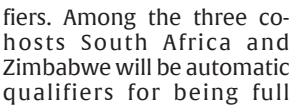
The 2027 ODI World Cup will be a three-stage competition leading to the finals and the 2028 T20 World Cup's Super 8 phase will be expanded to accommodate 10 teams, the ICC announced on Wednesday as it unveiled a revamped structure for the marquee events to achieve "greater context and consequence". The decisions were taken at the ICC Annual Conference here.

event, ensuring meaningful competition from the opening match through to the Finals," said the ICC in a statement.

The teams that would qualify 12th to 14th for the tournament will play the Super Series round and the top finisher will progress to round two of the competition that will see six teams divided into two groups. Top three teams from each group plus the next highest placed team across both groups will qualify for the Super 7 stage instead of the Super 6 planned earlier.

Four best-placed teams from the Super 7 stage will then progress to the semi-finals. "The increased consequence and enhanced competitive intensity promises to enhance the overall experience for fans while continuing to provide emerging teams with the opportunity to compete on cricket's biggest stage," said the ICC.

The tournament will feature 10 automatic quali-



members. The third co-host, Namibia, has not received an automatic qualification as it is an associate member. The

eight highest teams on the ODI rankings will complete the top 10 line-up. The remaining four teams will be

Super 10 instead of Super 8 at T20 World Cup: For the T20 showpiece in the Australia

and New Zealand in 2028, the ICC has decided to try Super 10 instead of the Super 8 after the Group stage.

Five groups of four teams will be created and top two from each enter the Super 10.

Instead of top two teams from each Super 8 group making the semifinals in the last edition, only the one that tops the table in each group enters the last four.

Teams placed second in groups play in the eliminator against the teams placed third in the opposite group, adding another layer to the competition.

"Encouraged by the performance of emerging teams in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2026, the ICC has decided to increase the number of teams competing in the second stage of the tournament from 8 to 10," said the ICC.

Scotland will enter directly into the Europe Regional Final, recognising the exceptional circumstances surrounding its participation in the 2026 tournament, having

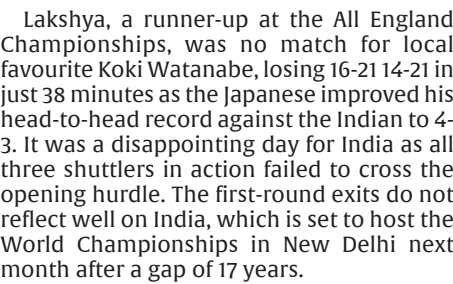
replaced Bangladesh in the 11th hour. The remaining teams that competed at the T20 World Cup 2026 but didn't secure automatic qualification will advance directly to the Global Qualifier. The other eight places in the Global Qualifier will be filled through regional qualification, with two teams each qualifying from Africa, Asia and Europe, and one team each from the Americas and East Asia-Pacific regions. The highest placed team from each region at the Global Qualifier, together with the next three highest-placed teams overall, will qualify for the T20 World Cup 2028.

"The new marquee tournament has been endorsed by the Board after being recommended by the ICC Development and Chief Executives' Committees. However, it will be finally approved by the Board after review by ICC's Finance & Commercial Affairs committee in the November meetings," the ICC added.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Tokyo

Young shuttlers Ayush Shetty and Unnati Hooda put up gallant fights before bowing out, while Lakshya Sen went down in straight games as India endured a disappointing second day at the Japan Open Super 750 badminton tournament here on Wednesday.

Ayush, a finalist at the Asia Championships, showed grit to recover after losing the opening game but ran out of steam in the end, going down 19-21 25-23 15-21 to second seed and former world champion Kunlavut Vitidsarn of Thailand in an 82-minute clash. World No. 24 Unnati, a two-time Odisha Open Super 1000 champion, once again lost to Huang Yu-Hsun, going down 21-16 16-21 15-21 to the Chinese Taipei shuttler for her second defeat in as many meetings.



Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu and the mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto remain India's only hopes in the \$950,000 tournament. While Sindhu will face fifth seed Han Yue of China, Dhruv and Tanisha will take on top seeds Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping in the second round on Thursday.

Ayush vs Kunlavut: Ayush, the 21-year-old from Mangaluru, came into the match after his sensational win over Kunlavut en route to the Asia Championships final, but knew it would not be a cakewalk against the Thai, a three-time world junior champion. The Indian made a decent start, opening up a 7-4 lead early on, but it disappeared in no time as Kunlavut surged ahead to 12-9. Ayush fought back to make it 13-12, but the Thai again moved ahead at 19-16. Three straight points gave Ayush hope, but Kunlavut sealed the opening game by winning the next two points.

After the change of ends, Kunlavut continued to hold the upper hand, but Ayush stayed in touch and managed to take a slender 11-10 lead at the interval.

The Thai, however, regained control and earned four match points, with the writing seemingly on the wall. But Ayush showed tremendous resolve, saving all four match points before prevailing in a tense exchange and converting his second game point.

The resurgence, however, proved short-lived as Kunlavut came back strongly in the decider, racing to an 8-5 lead and then extending it to 14-8 before sealing the contest comfortably.

D11062/26

Although every possible care and caution has been taken to avoid errors or omissions, this publication is being sold on the condition and understanding that information given in this publication is merely for reference and must not be taken as having authority of or binding in any way on the writers, editors, publishers, and printers and sellers who do not owe any responsibility for any damage or loss to any person, a purchaser of this publication or not for the result of any action taken on the basis of this work. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent court and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only. Readers are advised and requested to verify and seek appropriate advice to satisfy themselves about the veracity of any kind of advertisement before responding to any contents published in this newspaper. The printer, publisher, editor and any employee of the Pioneer Group's will not be held responsible for any kind of claim made by the advertisers of the products & services and shall not be made responsible for any kind of loss, consequences and further product-related damages on such advertisements.

Printed and published by Kushan Mitra for and on behalf of CPMK Printech Ltd., Regd Office:- 201-205, 208-210, 2nd Floor, Pratap Bhawan 5, B.S.Z. Marg, New Delhi-110002 Phone: 011-46035729, and printed at The Indian Express Ltd., A-8, Sector 7, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) Noida-201 301, Ph: 01202470700. Executive Editor Deepak Kumar Jha. AIR SURCHARGE of ₹ 2.00 East: Calcutta, North: Leh West: Mumbai & Ahmedabad South: Bangalore & Chennai. Central : Khajuraho. Lucknow Office: 4th Floor, Sahara Shopping Centre, Faizabad Road, Lucknow-226 016. Phone:- 9415089265